

**DEPARTMENT OF HISTORY, ARCHAEOLOGY
AND POLITICAL STUDIES,**

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KEY WORDS , CONCEPTS AND ACRONYMS IN THE TEXT

The following words feature in this module. While we highlight them at the outset, they are defined effectively at the end of each lesson. They are:

Lesson I

Africa, history, Sources, Palaeobotany, palaeontology, non-literate.

Lesson 2

Archaeology, Artifact, Excavation, Dendrochronology, biocultural evolution.

Lesson 3

Absolute chronology, genetic classification, Glottochronology,
Historical Linguistics, Language, Relative Chronology, Typological Classification.

Lesson 4

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Ancient Evidence, Hieroglyphic.

Lesson 5

Hamite, USSR, SOAS, SAPES, CODESRIA, OSSREA.

Lesson 6

Africanity, Afrocentricity

Lesson 7

‘Abaseni ba Omuse’

Lesson 8

Purposive sampling, snow ball sampling.

MODULE AHT 100: SOURCES OF AFRICAN HISTORY

LESSON ONE

1.0 MEANING AND SCOPE OF HISTORY

1.1 Introduction

In this lesson, we are concerned with the meaning of the concept ‘Sources of African History’ and the scope of the subject of history. We intend to prepare you for the further topics which follow this lesson. In doing this the lesson will explain clearly what the subject of history covers and its relevance in our day to day life.

1.2 Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Define the concepts of ‘Africa’, ‘History’, and ‘Sources’ clearly. ➤
- Discuss the scope of History as a subject.

1.3 Content

In discussing the concept ‘sources of African History’ you should note

Note:

There are three key words that will concern us. They are ‘Africa’, ‘History’ and ‘Sources’.

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It is necessary to define their operative applications in our study.

‘Africa’ is often understood to define the Black peoples’ continent. The name ‘Africa’ which is given to the entire continent emanates from North Africa. ‘Africa’ originally designated north-eastern Tunisia, then it broadened to refer to the entire territories of Tunisia and Algeria. Progressively the term covered North Africa before eventually being applied to refer to the whole continent. Thus Black people living on the continent are known as ‘Africans’

However, ‘Africa’ or ‘Africans’ does also refer to those African descendants who stay on other continents such as Europe, the Americas, Asia and Australia. This latter group is usually characterized as the ‘Africans in the diaspora’. These Africans in the diaspora reached those other continents due to several reasons including adventure, slave trade, exile and migration.

Note:

Not all present day Africans in the diaspora are able to socially, culturally and historically associate with Africa. The period of time which has passed since their ancestors went or were exported to the diaspora may be the reason for this inability.

Indeed some Africans of the diaspora still do associate with the African continent.

Conversely, ‘Africans’ is increasingly being applied to all residents of the African continent. In this sense, even the whites in Southern Africa, Asians in East Africa and Lebanese in West Africa qualify as Africans. It is important to stress this fact by stating as follows:

Note:

A person can be black without being African and be African without being black.

Consequently, in looking at African Sources, the note will be needed. Works by non-Blacks or by Blacks in the diaspora are judged based on their views about Africa and its indigenous inhabitants. Besides, their importance to our reconstruction of African history will have to be of greater value before we give their views space.

Activity:

What do the concepts of ‘Africa’ or ‘Africans’ refer to? Illustrate your answer

The next concept is ‘History’. What is History? How does it differ from other subjects? To address these questions, we start by briefly stating that history is a story about people and their past activities. These activities include social, political economics, religious and technological aspects. As an academic discipline, history started in the European world in the 19th century. Unlike other disciplines, history is preoccupied with

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change over time. Any discussion that ignores this characteristic does history a disservice. Hence history traces all the various fields noting their development over time.

Note:

You should realise that history demonstrates developmental changes among human beings and their environment over time.

In examining the scope of history, we argue that since history is about people and their environment, then it is as old as mankind. From available evidence, mankind first lived in Africa, particularly in the land of the Great Lakes.

Activity:

What does the term 'Great Lakes' refer to?

Yet early European scholars, traders, travellers, soldiers and administrators denied Africa its rightful contribution in history. In fact, such scholars as W.F. Hegel, Hugh Trevor-Roper and A.P. Newton alleged that there was no history in Africa. Hegel even compartmentalized Africa arguing that the northern part of Africa was not part of Africa.

According to Hegel Africa is situated south of the Sahara. This concept incidentally seems to be stuck with us because we often hear terms like 'sub-Saharan' Africa in reference to areas where the Arab community is less dominant. Yet we know that before the desiccation of the Sahara, Africa was clearly one entity inhabited by mainly the black community.

Such misconception about African history derives from several factors. They include racism. Scholars like Hegel saw only people of the Caucasoid stock as being capable of making history. He argued that history began in Asia and reached its climax in Western Europe.

Activity:

Explain the area which is generally referred to as western Europe

The second factor was ignorance about the broad range of sources which non-literate societies employ to transmit their history. Given that a great portion of Africa was occupied by non-literate societies, it becomes clear that ignorant white people could not discern any history in the southern part of Africa. Racists like Hegel, Newton and Roper wrongly believed that history existed only in a written form.

Activity:

What then is the scope of African history?

The foregoing lays enough background which can build on in defining the concept of 'sources'.

Activity:

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What is a source? What is a source of history?
How many sources of history exist and are useful
in the reconstruction of African history?

Oxford English Dictionary (Second Edition) defines a 'source' as a work, an object or a person that supplies information about a fact, an event, another person, persons or a community, among others. The information supplied may be first hand or second hand. First hand information constitute primary data while second hand forms secondary data. Thus a source can provide primary or secondary information or evidence which serves as raw materials for researchers, students as well as professionals in their various academic and professional endeavours.

A source of history consequently is any work, object or person(s) that supplies information or evidence which is employed by historians during the process of historical reconstruction. Sources of history encompass every kind of information or evidence which human beings have left of their past activities. Such evidence or information may be obtained through the spoken word, the written or printed word, the shape of the landscape and the material artifacts.

Note:

It is important to note that the spoken word includes even taped materials whereas the printed word includes the material on the internet.

Many sources of history are obtained by employing a variety of methods which require history students to familiarize themselves with by consulting many disciplines. These disciplines include geology, palaeontology, palaeobotany, radio-activity, geography, sociology, oral tradition and oral history, archeology, economics, population studies and linguistics.

Activity:

The list of disciplines is inexhaustible. Which other disciplines can you add?

We wish to end this section by quoting from a renowned historian, Arther Marwick, in his book The Nature of History. His views are as follows:

'All historical study is founded upon the critical evaluation of a wider range of evidence in that the teaching of history stresses the complexity of evaluating evidence and provides skills in the handling of source materials. It offers a good antidote to the deluge of information, misinformation and propaganda which pouring forth from all organs of mass media threaten to swamp all of us'.

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The extract is taken from the second edition of Marwick's book which came out in 1981 on page 21. Thus a careful handling of sources enables history practitioners generate knowledge that is useful to contemporary society.

1.4 Summary

In this lesson we have defined the meaning of the concept 'sources of African history'. We have also argued that history is as old as mankind and that Africa being the birth-place of mankind is also the home of history. Hence the scope of history goes back to the origin of mankind.

Activity:

- (1) Discuss with examples your understanding of the concept sources of African History.
- (2) Why did some Europeans allege that Africa did not have history before their coming?

1.5 Definition of Key Words

Africa - Refers to the continent on which Black people predominate. 'Africans' refers to both Black people as well as other races who have made Africa their permanent home. Black people in the diaspora are referred to as Africans in the diaspora.

History- Generally refers a story about people and their past activities. It is as old as mankind.

Non-literate - Applies to societies which lived without the existence of any knowledge about the art of reading and writing in their vicinity.

Palaeobotany - The scientific study of ancient plant remains.

Palaeontology - The scientific study of ancient material remains as evidence of past life.

Sources - A work, an object or a person that supplies information about a fact, an event, another person, persons or a community.

1.6 Further Reading

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LESSON TWO

2.0 ARCHAEOLOGY AS A SOURCE OF HISTORY

2.5 DEFINITION OF TERMS

Archaeology: This word is derived from two Greek words, Archios meaning ancient or old and Logos - word or study (Rhoda 1964). Hence, broadly speaking it can be defined as the study the past, the old or antiquities as a means of reconstructing the past.

However, archaeology could comprehensively be defined as a science discipline which aims at a systematically studying the human cultural and social past through excavation, description, explanation and analysis of man's past (relics) artifacts in the context in which they are found (Mutoro, 1992).

Artifact: Is a Latin word derived from arte-skill and facere - to make. It thus means items of material culture made with skills.

Excavation: Has its origin from the Latin word "excavatus" which means to dig from the ground. Today, and to any layman, the word excavation is regarded as being synonymous with simply digging up the ground with a deliberate attempt to uncover or expose by digging the ground.

2.1 INTRODUCTION

In lesson I we looked at the meaning and scope of 'sources of African history'. We now turn to archaeology as a source of African history.

Archaeology is one of the subjects which historians study in order to acquire information for reconstruction of the past. This is because it collaborates or criticizes other evidence like oral tradition and written sources thus enriching evidence for historical writing. Apart from this, it broadens historical studies to cover the entire span of human

existence, from its remote beginning to the present. Additionally it provides dates which are valuable in historical writing.

2.2 OBJECTIVES

The learners should be able to:

- Define archaeology and state reasons why archaeology should be studied. ➤
- Discuss the steps that are followed during archaeological investigation ➤
- Explain relative and chronometric dating methods used in archaeology.
- Explain the role of archaeology in historical reconstruction.

2.3 CONTENT

Why Study Archaeology?

1. Archaeology is studied in order to understand the fundamental archaeological entities, processes, artefacts attributes and types of assemblage. In this way, it provides material information on the technology of a people, their basic economy, possibly the rough size of their social units, their burial practices and to some extent their artistic achievements.
2. Archaeology brings to everyone – layman and scholars the unprecedented opportunity to see reconstructed ancient sites, and thus to understand history better. In this respect, it widens the perspectives of history in accord to the needs of today. It helps us in the understanding of the present through carrying out of researches about human behaviour in general.
3. Archaeology is key to understanding African (and any other) civilization. In the absence of written records, archaeology is very important in historical reconstruction since it is able to go back at least 4 million years ago when humanity began. It is thus the most profitable inquiry in the search for the origin of epoch in order to understand the history of civilization.
4. A nation without a past (Archaeology) has no soul according to the 1st President of Botswana (Mogae). It is through the study of archaeology that we have been able to honour the achievement of our people. This is because, the concern of the past is basic to humanity since the traditional fabric shared by members of a particular society was the source of their solidarity and pride. If we take examples from Zimbabwe, Ghana, Egypt, Kenya and Israel we note that: on attainment of independence, Southern Rhodesia changed her name to Zimbabwe – after its largest historical monument; Gold Coast changed to Ghana – after the ruins of one of the ancient kingdoms in West Africa, despite the fact that this kingdom is not even situated where modern Ghana is.

The Egyptians call their national football team, the Pharaoh's – after the achievement of their ancient rulers who contributed greatly in science, medicine, architecture, mathematics, irrigation science and so on. Kenya on her part is considered as a country with the longest history from the paleological and archaeological materials recovered here. Israel as her part sends its recruit soldiers on the graduation/passing out parade to an archaeological site (Masada) where they swear to defend Israel the way those zealots who died defending Masada did. In this instant, Jewish defenders held Masada during the revolt of AD 66-73. Rather than surrender to the mighty of Rome, 960 defenders committed suicide. In this respect therefore, archaeology help emerging nations establish a cultural heritage.

5. Archaeology has much to offer to assist historians and other specialists working from written sources/records particularly those interested in oral tradition. The use of archaeology in establishing architectural history; settlement size, trade, industry and everyday life of the Muslim towns of East Africa or the West African towns is too obvious to detail. In other words, archaeology is vital in corroborating or criticizing other evidence for historical reconstructions.
 6. Archaeology provides useful information on the possible origins and spread of domesticates and human population in a way that was thought inaccessible a few years ago. From the co-operation of the palaeobotanists who are providing evidence for both the origins of (Africans) staple crops and their former environments, using pollen analytical methods or detailed ecological studies, the archeologist are able to suggest the former movement of peoples or influences and detail the human ecology played on those matters.
 7. Archaeology is studied because individuals want to pursue a career in such areas as
 - research scientists, teachers/scholars, company executives, journalists, publications, cultural resource officers and business advisors.
- (i) Research scientists are in great demand in the National Museums of Kenya and Kenya National Archives. In the Museums Archaeology graduates are employed as curators where they act as site interpreters and conservationists. In this respect they are also handy to the tourist industry since they interpret the sites thus promoting cultural tourism. Indeed, Kenya Wildlife Service and other conservationist bodies all over the world need to employ archaeologists because they will be able to explain human contributions to the evolution of the landscapes currently occupied by wildlife. As research scientists they act as educators and formulators of policies that act as a guide towards human and nature studies. Again, if we have to talk about African renaissance, like President Thabo Mbeki of South Africa, we need to have informed policy makers especially in past African achievement so that we can learn from them and face the future with confidence.
 - (ii) Teachers, though not paid well and in time are able to communicate vast knowledge of human experience to the young generation.

- (iii) Company executives with an archaeological and historical bias are in great demand in the western world especially in areas of commerce and industry because these graduates have exceptional analytical skills necessary to make decisions. Such companies spend less on consultancies since such graduates are able to put temporal experience on that company at any time. It is worth noting that such graduates have knowledge about particular problems which took place in the past and how they were resolved.
- (iv) Journalism: Archaeology and other social scientists like historians are the only people qualified to react to western propaganda since they understand how those societies have evolved. Western rhetorics and biases can be counteracted by producing local programmes for the media or by becoming full-time journalists like Kwendo Opanga, Warigi Gitau, John Kamau among others in our local media industry.

Likewise, we can romanticise archaeology and produce television programmes like it has been done elsewhere. Such epics as Conan, Robinson Crusoe and Giovanni Belzoni – the rave robber have been produced and are hilariously charming and their producers have made a fortune. These are based on true archaeological/historical episodes.

- (v) Publishers. Archaeologists can work in tandem with the producers of books and add such topics as evolution among other issues and encourage children and the general public to read.
- (vi) Legal Advisors on business matters to the custom department and businessmen. Archaeologists can advice the business community on the need of giving information concerning meaning/symbolism in curios, for example, the current president of Mali (2002) who is an archaeologist has instituted legislation conserving the sale of such items.
- (vii) Scholars – many archaeologists are engaged in research and teaching in many universities and research centres all over the world. While here, some act as consultants on matters concerning cultural resource management or more specifically Archaeological Heritage management.

8. Archaeology is also studied for its intrinsic value where it is learnt for its own sake. Grahame Clarke confirms this when he wrote:
“the study of pre-history stand in no more need of justification than the exploration of the physical nature and mathematical properties of the universe...” In this case, archaeology enlarges the range of human experiences and enriches the quality of life.

Note:

Therefore, archaeology is studied because it offers many solutions to humanity and as such no development can take

place without it. In this respect, South Africa, Botswana, Namibia and Mali have integrated it into their curriculum in all levels of education (It thus enhances the interpretation of social and physical realities of our universe) **METHODS OF ARCHAEOLOGICAL INVESTIGATION**

DEFINITION OF A SITE

Note:

There are six issues that will concern us.
These are 'site', 'site discovery', 'site survey', 'excavation' evidence interpretation, 'preservation of recovered objects'.

Archaeologists seem to have always disagreed on what is meant by an archaeological site (Coles 1972). They however agree that sites are those points/areas on the landscape which show material evidence of human activities in the past. One can reject as a site an area that does not have enough concentration of cultural remains per square metre he is looking for. Therefore the decision whether an area is a site depends on the decision of an archaeologist. The size of a site is determined by the extent and density of visible surface remains.

There are several indicators of an archaeological site. These includes:-

1. Those areas which are conspicuously above the ground level. These can be stone ruins, pyramids, burial mounds and other related features.
2. **Vegetation cover.** In places where the soil has been disturbed for example where there were cattle pens or middens, the vegetation cover may be healthy because of the nitrogen and phosphorous content in that soil is very high. Conversely, stunted vegetation or very poor growth of vegetation may be an indicator of a site. Vegetation on concrete sub-surface will be very short.
3. **Soil colour.** In places where past human activities had taken place, for example, where villages had been abandoned you find dark organic soils which when ploughed show dark zones.
4. Surface finds of artifacts, for example, where there are concentrations of potsherds, bones, stone tools and other cultural debris that stand out from the surrounding ground.

METHODS OF SITE DISCOVERY

1. **Accidental:** There has been several accidental site discoveries, for example when Masinga dam was being constructed, a lot of artifacts were found which reflected that there was an Iron Age Site.

2. **Aerial Photography:** By taking photographs from the plane you can be able to discover where sites were located.
3. **Remote Sensing:** Is the process whereby satellites take pictures of the earth's surface and these photographs reveal the various configurations of the earth's surface.
4. **Restivity Surveys: Here,** one uses a magnetometer to measure the direct electrical resistance of the soil between disturbed and undisturbed areas. Where there is a ditch the electrical current will be measured very well and where there was a road, the electrical current will not be measured so well.
5. Site prospecting by walking and driving. This is by seeking information from locals and moving around the terrain, recording, drawing sketches and taking photographs of all promising sites.

Activity:

Explain key indicators of an archaeological site and methods used during site discovery.

SITE SURVEY

Site surveying is the simplest way of getting some ideas about the site's extent. Site surveys are done by studying the distribution of surviving features and recording and possibly collecting artifacts from the surveys of various areas.

The first form of survey is mapping. Mapping enables you to accurately record the survey data. For surface features like building and roads you use topographical maps. These maps enables one to relate the ancient settlements to the basic features of the natural landscape. Planimetric maps on the other hand are used in relating different archaeological features to each other, for example, the relationship between the burial ground and the settlement.

There are two main ways of collecting fossils and artifacts from a site:-

1. Collecting everything from the surface of the site. This approach of total collection is used in those areas where little archaeological research has been done.
2. Collecting diagnostic artifacts. This is done when one is dealing with a well- known area and one just needs these artifacts for further survey or study.

EXCAVATION

Excavation is a major undertaking in which archaeologists acquire data about the past. Unlike surveys which recovers data from the surface, excavation recovers data from beneath the ground.

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Sites are chosen for excavation because it is hoped that they will provide the information that will give some guidance about prehistoric past. But it should be noted that all excavations are destructive and therefore every cautionary measure must be considered before embarking on any form of excavation. In this regard, those sites chosen for excavation are chosen only when they are threatened by destruction and the choice of a site to excavate stem from the research problem. Research problems may include reasons for evolution of a culture, social organization of a community or environmental exploitation by a prehistoric group and so on.

Excavation yields 2 kinds of information:

- 1) About human activities at a particular period in the past. 2) Those activities from period to period.

Contemporary activities take place horizontally in space whereas changes in those activities occur vertically through time.

In horizontal dimension, archaeologists try to demonstrate a contemporaneity, that is, the activities did occur at the same time by proving through excavation that artifacts and other features are found in association in an undisturbed context.

In the vertical dimension archaeologists analyse changes through time by the study of stratigraphy. An excavated vertical profile showing a series of layers constitutes a sequence that has accumulated through time.

PRACTICAL CONSIDERATION TO TAKE IN MIND BEFORE EMBARKING ON AN EXCAVATION

1. Permission to excavate.
The permit comes from the National Museums of Kenya, the owner of the land and the President. The National Museums of Kenya is mandated through legislation - Cap. 218 to be the custodian of all archaeological heritage in Kenya.
2. Accessibility. This determines whether you will walk, use a vehicle, a boat or aircraft to reach a particular site.
3. Finance. This depends on the type of excavation one wants to carry out.

EXCAVATION STRATEGY

Excavation strategy is determined partly by nature of the research problem and partly by the nature of practical consideration.

Excavation strategy must be flexible so that one can find material representing cultures that are not reflected in the surface material. To do this, one must have knowledge about the site before excavating. Two approaches are used to get such knowledge including:-

- a) Surface collection
- b) Remote Sensing

Every excavation starts with a testing strategy which consists of excavating small squares in the deposits so as to obtain a preliminary understanding of the sites stratigraphy and variation in archaeological debris.

There are 2 basic excavation methods or strategies:

1. Area or horizontal method. Its objective is to uncover large areas on the ground in the search of the entire settlement patterns. This is done on relatively large scale and is designed to uncover household and other activities that are normally discovered only by digging over an extensive area.
2. Vertical excavation method. It is designed to uncover stratigraphic information or a sequence of occupation layers on a small scale. Vertical excavation is done when artifact samples are a primary concern. Once you have excavated, the next step is recording.

Once an artifact has been recovered it must be given a number which is entered in a catalogue in the bag it is stored. Your day-to-day progress of excavation is recorded in your site note book, for example, what you did that day, how many centimeters you dug, which square and what was recovered?

Features and structures would not only be recorded in the site notebook but should also be accurately drawn and photographed.

Recording is usually followed by classification of materials found in a site. After classification, what follows is laboratory analysis and preservation. The final part constitutes report writing.

Activity:

Explain horizontal and vertical excavation methods.

THE INTERPRETATION OF EVIDENCE

All the study of the past (prehistory) is indeed, based on the very rigorous interpretation of sources available (i.e. received from an excavation). What one could find out therefore, is naturally conditioned by the nature of his sources.

It is a well known fact that each evidence has its potentialities, and its possibilities, but also its limitations and drawbacks. The evidence used by archaeologist that of cultural material objects (artifacts) or structures surviving from prehistoric times has its limitations. Obviously, it is not possible to find out from fragments of pottery, or from the post-holes

of an otherwise vanished wooden house, what language their makers spoke, or what they thought about life after death or how their social system was organised. However, burial practices do help to shed some light on the inhabitants' beliefs of "life-after-death". This is basically based on the recovered artifacts (especially households) found associated with some burials and also on the positioning of the dead bodies. Prehistoric art perhaps gives the archaeologist more reliable evidences pertinent to such practices like magico-religious beliefs than anything else available.

Nonetheless, what is actually required is to study the accidentally durable remnants of human activities in an attempt to try to reconstruct the past history of the inhabitants who left such items thousand of years ago.

PRESERVATION OF RECOVERED OBJECTS

This calls for extreme care. Objects of metal and sometimes pottery are often found in a very poor state of preservation, and their removal is attended to by a considerable risk of damage. This risk, can of course be lessened by allowing the object to dry thoroughly before touching it at all. Direct source of heat or warmth must be avoided as this tends to disintegrate artifacts. Where it is practicable, a whole block of soil in which the object is embedded could be removed, and its excavation completed under safer conditions at home or in the laboratory.

Human bones are preserved for professional examination by physical anthropologists and other related professionals, who are normally able to determine from the bones the age and sex of the individuals, their height and the ethnic group to which they probably belonged. This information is derived chiefly from the skull and lower jaw, the limbs bones, and the pelvis which are accordingly the most important bones to preserve. Acetone is usually applied to such specimens immediately after the exposure, including even the soil around them, so as to prevent them from disintegrating into powder. Acetone can also be used on stone implements.

Examination of skeletons recovered from archaeological excavation normally attempt to reveal signs of diseases, wounds, or fracture that might have been the cause of death. Cremated bones are also preserved in this manner as carefully as skeletons.

DATING METHODS

Dating is one of the key essentials in putting sites and fossils into a chronological framework. Archaeologists, geologists, paleontologists and other scientists date their evidence using either:- a) Relative dating - 'as old as' or b) chronometrical dating - 'absolute'

Activity:

Why date?

In trying to trace the story about what happened in the long history of the world past, one of the difficulties is to say just 'when' different events took place. Where there are no written

records to give us dates, other methods have been devised to date the various things that we know took place.

1. To interpret the archaeological materials by dating various morphological aspects of human development and his materials. This is important because there cannot be prove of theory about biocultural process unless time is controlled. This involves man evolution from anthropoid like creatures to the current homo sapiens and the evolution of his technology from oldowan simple tools to the present information age.
2. Rigorous dating does help in eliminating any falsehood given to a find. In this case, Piltdown (England) man who had been given a wrong date of 2.75 million years has been redated to 320,000 only. Likewise, 'Lucy', Australopithecine Afarensis from Omo valley in Ethiopia had been given a Romantic date of 4.5 million years but this has been revised through $K^{40}A^{40}$ to 2.75 million years.
3. Archaeological dating have also been used to authenticate dates given by historians. A case in point was Herodotus who wrote about the construction of the great pyramid - the temple of Pharoah Khafre and his date is confirmed by archaeological date. Likewise, many biblical dates have been confirmed or disputed by archaeological dating.
4. Dating has helped historians to understand that human development has never been the same all over the world at the same time. From archaeological dating we learn that man first evolved in Africa, fire was first used in Kenya and possibly later in China and that Egypt ruled Asia, and that there has never been equal development in the world.
5. Dating itself helps archaeologists to reconstruct history from artifacts. In this, periods are given to events. It is in dating that archaeologists accomplishes the delineation of synchronic segments for example in the 19th C Jurgesen Christian Thomsem came up with the three age system (stone, bronze and iron) through relative dating of archaeological materials. A classification which is valid to date and is used extensively by historians.

Activity:

Discuss relative and chronometric methods of dating used in archaeology.

Relative Dating

Is sub-divided into four sub-divisions which are, R₁, R₂, R₃ and R₄. R₁ denotes primary sequence, that is, the age in relation of a find to the deposit which it was found. For example fossils like Australopithecus Africanus found embedded in Brecia. R₂ denotes a local sequence that has been dated for example 'stone bowl culture', 'dimple base pottery'

(urewe ware) etc. R_3 denotes the dating of objects compared to a world-wide situation, for example, the morphology of man during Pleistocene period.

R_4 denotes the dating of fossils by looking at their morphology, for example, size of the brain, jaw and so on.

Examples of relative dating methods:-

- a) Stratigraphy
- b) Fluorine analysis

(i) Stratigraphy

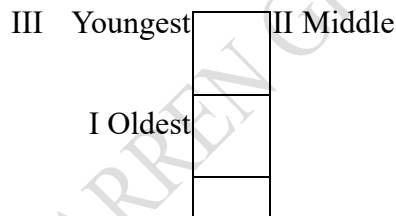
Relative dating as used here tell you something is older, or, younger, than something else. If, for example a skull were found at depth of 10 meters and another at 20 metres at the same site, we usually assume the skull discovered at 20 meters is older. We may not know how old. It however give us some idea of evolutionary changes in skull morphology (structure) especially if a number of skulls at different levels were found and compared. Its focus is thus stratigraphic and is based upon the law of superimposition, which states that a lower stratum (layer) is older than a higher stratum (layer).

Note:

This is important, because the earth crust is laid down by layers of sedimentary rocks which are valuable in reconstructing the history of the earth and life on it.

You can therefore say, event A took place before event B which in turn took place before C, but you may not know within two or three centuries or how many years BC or AD any of them took place (Hole and Heizer 1973). See figure I below.

Fig. I



Disadvantage

It does not account for earth's activities such as volcanic activity, river activity, and mountain building, among others which sometimes alters the stratum.

(ii) Fluorine Analysis

It applies only to bones (Oakley, 1963). It works on the assumption that bones in the earth are exposed to seepage of groundwater, usually containing fluorine. Fluorine in the water combines with the bones calcium to form a compound, fluorapatite. The amount of fluorapatite in various bones in a site determines their contemporaneity or lack thereof.

That; the longer bones lie in the earth the more fluorine they incorporate during the fossilization process. Therefore bones deposited at the same time in the same location (stratigraphic equivalence) should contain the same amount of fluorapatite. The use of this technique by Professor Oakley of the British Museum in early 1950's exposed the Piltdown (England) hoax by demonstrating that the human skull was considerably older than the jaw (of a young *Urang Utang*) found with it.

Disadvantage

Fluorine is only useful with bones found at the same location. Because the amount of fluorine in ground water is based on the local river system and local conditions, it varies from place to place. Also some ground water may not contain any fluorine. For these reasons, comparing bones from different localities by fluorine analysis is impossible.

Like stratigraphy, fluorine analysis does not give us the age of the stratum and the objects in it.

To determine actual (absolute) number of years a variety of chronometric techniques based on the phenomenon of radio-active decay have been developed by scientists. Some of these includes:-

- a) Uranium 238 (^{238}U)
- b) Potassium 40 (^{40}K) of K/Ar
- c) Carbon 14 (^{14}C)

Other absolute dating methods include:-

- d) Archaeomagnetism/palaeomagnetism
- e) Dendrochronology
- f) Varve chronology

Radio-Active Decay Methods

Note:

Chronometric radio-active techniques are based on the theory that; certain radioactive isotopes of elements are unstable, disintegrate, and form isotopic variation of another element. Since the rate of disintegration follows a definite mathematical pattern the radioactive material forms an accurate geological time clock. By measuring the amount of disintegration in a particular sample, the number of years it took for the amount to decay is then known.

Chronometric techniques, have been used for dating the immense age of the earth as well as artifacts less than a thousand years old.

(i) URANIUM 238 (^{238}U)

Uranium²³⁸ decays to form lead with a half life of 4.5 billion years, that is, one half the original amount of ^{238}U is lost in 4.5 billion years, and through various processes become lead. Therefore if a piece of rock is measured and half of the uranium has been converted to lead the age of that piece of rock is 4.5 billion years. In another 4.5 billion years, the remaining 238 U would be decaying and so on. The isotope ^{238}U has proven a useful tool in dating the age of the formation of the earth.

(ii) POTASSIUM 40 (^{40}K)/potassium argon ($^{40}\text{K}/^{40}\text{Ar}$)

Potassium 40 produces Argon 40. It has a half life of 1.3 billion years.

How it works

Rocks that provide the best samples for K/Ar are those heated to extremely high temperatures such as that generated by volcanic activity. When the rock is in a molten state, Argon 40 a gas, is driven off. As the rock cools and solidifies, Argon 40 (^{40}Ar), but now the gas is physically trapped in the cooled rock.

In order to obtain the date of the rock, it is reheated and the escaping gas measured. Potassium/Argon has been used for dating very old events such as the age of the earth as well as those less than 100,000 years old.

This method has been used extensively in dating material in the 1 to 5 million years range especially in East Africa.

Weaknesses of ^{238}U and $^{40}\text{K}/^{40}\text{Ar}$

They deal with inorganic materials and therefore organic materials like bones cannot be measured. They measure rock matrix in which the bones are found.

(iii) CARBON 14 (^{14}C)

Carbon 14 has a half life of 5730 years. This method has been used to date materials from less than 1000 years to as much as 70,000 years although the probability of error rises rapidly after 40,000 years.

Its Rationale

Cosmic radiation enters the earth's atmosphere producing neutrons which react with nitrogen to produce a radio-active isotope of carbon which is carbon 14. As the carbon 14 is diffused around the earth with the earth's rotation it mixes with carbon 12 and is absorbed by plants in their life processes. It is then transferred to the herbivorous animals that feed on plants and carnivorous that feed on herbivorous. Thus carbon 14 and carbon 12 are found in all living forms at a fixed ration.

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When the organism dies, it no longer absorbs carbon 14 which then decays at a constant rate to nitrogen 14. It takes 5730 years for half the amount of carbon 14 to become nitrogen 14. For example, if you collect charcoal remains from a site and you find that the proportions of the carbon 14 to carbon 12 shows only 25% of the original carbon 14 remaining, and we know that it takes 5730 years for the half of the carbon 14 atoms to become nitrogen 14 and another 5730 years for the remaining to become nitrogen 14 then the sample must be about 11,460 years old.

Half the remaining carbon 14 will become nitrogen 14 in the next 5730 years, leaving 12.5 percent of the original amount. This process continues until there will be little carbon 14 left after 40,000 years when measuring becomes difficult.

Advantage

It gives dates of objects we deal with (of organic origin) and it is usually very accurate.

Weakness

1. It gives smaller dates of upto 70,000 years.
2. It relies only on organic materials.
3. Handling can lead to contamination leading to an error.

None of these methods is precise. Each method is based with many problems that must be carefully considered during laboratory measurement and in the collection of materials to be measured. Because all these methods are imprecise, we give approximate dates with a plus (+) or a minus (-) factor.

(iv) Archaeomagnetism/Palaeomagnetism

It depends upon the peculiarities of the earth's magnetic forces to yield dates from fired clay or otherwise with an accuracy of 50 years. It works on the known fact that: when clay is fired the magnetic and hematite grains align with the magnetic field of the earth. If the approximate locale of firing is known, as well as, the position and angle in which the object was fired, a date can be assigned by knowing at what time the magnetic field of the earth was in a matching plane. This technique is based on the shifting nature of the earth's magnetic north pole. Today, magnetic or pole is located northward, but this situation has not always been so. In our present ethnographic point of view, we call northern orientation 'normal' and a southern one 'reversed'.

Weakness

This method is used mostly to confirm dates derived from other methods.

(v) Dendrochronology

It is used as a dating technique as well as providing valuable information on past environment and climate.

The method is based on the fact that trees lay down one growth ring of cells annually. The method is only useful if the individual rings can be counted. This is done backwards from timber of known dates, matching the patterns of variation through a process known as cross-dating.

In some cases a sequence of cross dated timber may be determined but without link to the modern day. This is known as floating chronology. A special instance of the use of dendro-chronology is the checking of radio-carbon dating. By joining rings of dead and living timber, it has been possible for example to date trees extending well beyond 8000 years ago.

(vi) Varve Chronology

Varve chronology like dendrochronology relies on an annual deposition of morainic materials. Each year, during winter glacier (ice) thaws and deposits moraine materials. These accumulate yearly and it is easy to determine when the site was occupied and the subsequent number of years that have elapsed since its abandonment. This is mostly carried out in cold latitudes like Europe, America and northern Asia.

2.4 SUMMARY AND CONCLUSION

In this lecture, we have looked at the following:

- Meaning of archaeology
- Methods of archaeological investigation
- Dating methods in archaeology

We have seen some of the reasons why the study of archaeology is important, not only for historical reconstruction but the general development of the individual and the world at large.

One of the cardinal sources of the pre-colonial history in Africa is archaeology. Archaeological findings shed invaluable insights on man's existence, his environment and activities in time and space. The significance of archaeology, as a source of history lies in its ability to go back - a period for which written sources may be lacking and transcends the limitations of oral sources.

Activity:

1. Discuss the steps that are followed during archaeological reconstruction.
2. Why and how should archaeology be studied?
3. Discuss fluorine dating method and show its strength and weaknesses.
4. What are the strengths and weaknesses of dendrochronology and palaeomagnetism methods of dating?

2.5 Definition of key words

Dendrochronology - Refers to tree-ring analysis.

Biocultural evolution - Biological and cultural evolution.

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LESSON THREE

3.0 HISTORICAL LINGUISTICS AS A SOURCE OF AFRICAN HISTORY

3.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we learnt about archaeology as a source of history hoping to demonstrate the relevance of archaeology in the reconstruction of African history.

In this lesson we examine the meaning of historical linguistics and how historical linguistics can be employed in writing the history of any African communities. The discussion will look at linguistic classification, use of words, Bantu origin and expansion and chronology.

3.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson you should be able to:

- (i) Discuss linguistic classifications
- (ii) Demonstrate how 'words' can be useful in the writing of any African community's history.
- (iii) Analyse the Bantu origin and expansion.

3.3 Content

Linguistics is a scientific study of language. Language in turn is a pattern of conventional symbols which bring about communication. These symbols have been subjected to periodic social, technological, political, economic and environmental forces. These forces have caused changes in language, its speakers and locations.

Looking at such linguistic changes over time is therefore known as historical linguistics. Through historical linguistics, mankind's past can be reconstructed. In this reconstruction process, historical linguists classify languages as a way of beginning to study relationships between peoples. Several approaches are employed in classifying languages.

a) Genetic Classification

This classification is biologically skewed. It makes it possible to detect the kinship and hence the original relationships within a particular family of languages. Genetic classification provides the foundation for historical comparative linguistics whose basic task has been the reconstruction of ancestral languages. For instance, Bantu as an ancestral language gave rise to Zulu, Shona, Swahili among others.

Activity:

Can you state other Bantu groups?

b) Typological Classification

This is based on purely structural criteria. It examines the noun and verb forms. For example, 'eaiyua' and 'aiyua' or 'eeri', 'eeri', 'eeyi'.

These examples are derived from studies among the Kalenjin and Luyia language groups. While the Kalenjin have 'aiyua' for axe, the Abaluyia have 'eaiyua' for the same. Alternatively, whereas the Ancient Southern Nilotic Speakers and the Gusii have 'eeri' for 'male cow' or 'bull' the Abaluyia have 'eeyi' for 'ox'. These words involve resemblances in sound and meaning. Possible historical connections in the process of change can be detected in these concepts.

Activity:

Can you identify any other typologically similar words from different languages? Name them.

Note:

It is important to note that typological classification may be based on languages which are far removed from one another as Wolof (A language in Senegal) and English

Typological similarity in no way implies that the languages concerned are related. Conversely, typological differences do not necessarily mean that the languages bear no relationship to each other. Kiswahili, Luganda and other Bantu languages are related. However, whereas Kiswahili is non-tonal, others are tonal.

For instance, among the Mt. Kenya people depending on how 'iria' is pronounced, it can be used to refer to milk or sea respectively. Similar examples among the North Buluyia include 'khocha' which can refer to maternal uncle or sharpen especially a stick. Among the Gusii 'igoro' refers to 'yesterday' or 'up'. In some cases it is necessary to go beyond the lexicon and make a combined study of phonological, morphological and syntactical structures in order to identify kinship if any.

c) Geographical (Aerial) Classification

This is an elementary form. Languages that are physically close to each other are grouped together. For example we have West Atlantic group, Senegal-Guinea, or Niger-Chad. This category constitute what in principle is known as cultural area classification. The cultural classification approach ignores linguistic interpenetration resulting from migrations and invasions.

Note:

You should note that any valid classification must take account of all representative elements and demonstrate that the resemblances are neither by chance nor the outcome of borrowing.

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P. Diagne in his article titled 'History and linguistics, and theories on the races and history of Africa' contained in General History of Africa Vol.I argues that in some variants of Kiswahili, upto 60% of the words are of Arabic origin, yet in its actual structure, Kiswahili is an African language. For instance, in Kiswahili all words which contain one of the six phonemes, 'dh', 'gh', 'kh', 'q' and 'th' are borrowed from Arabic.

Christopher Ehret and the Nilotic Family LANGUAGE CHART

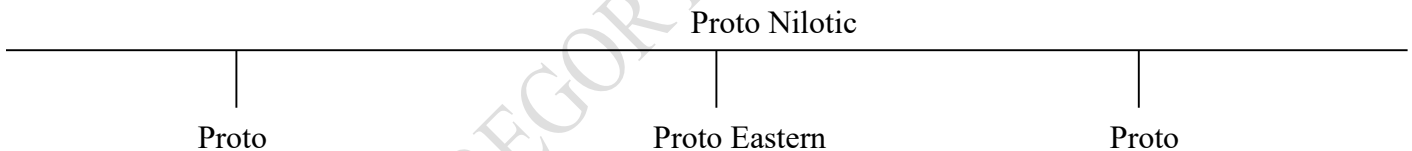
Christopher Ehret employed linguistic reconstruction to demonstrate the historical relationships between the Burun, Acholi, Luo, Lotuko, Teso, Karamojong, Massai, Datoga, Nandi and Pokot.

Activity:

Draw the map of Africa and plot on it locations where the above people live in bigger numbers.

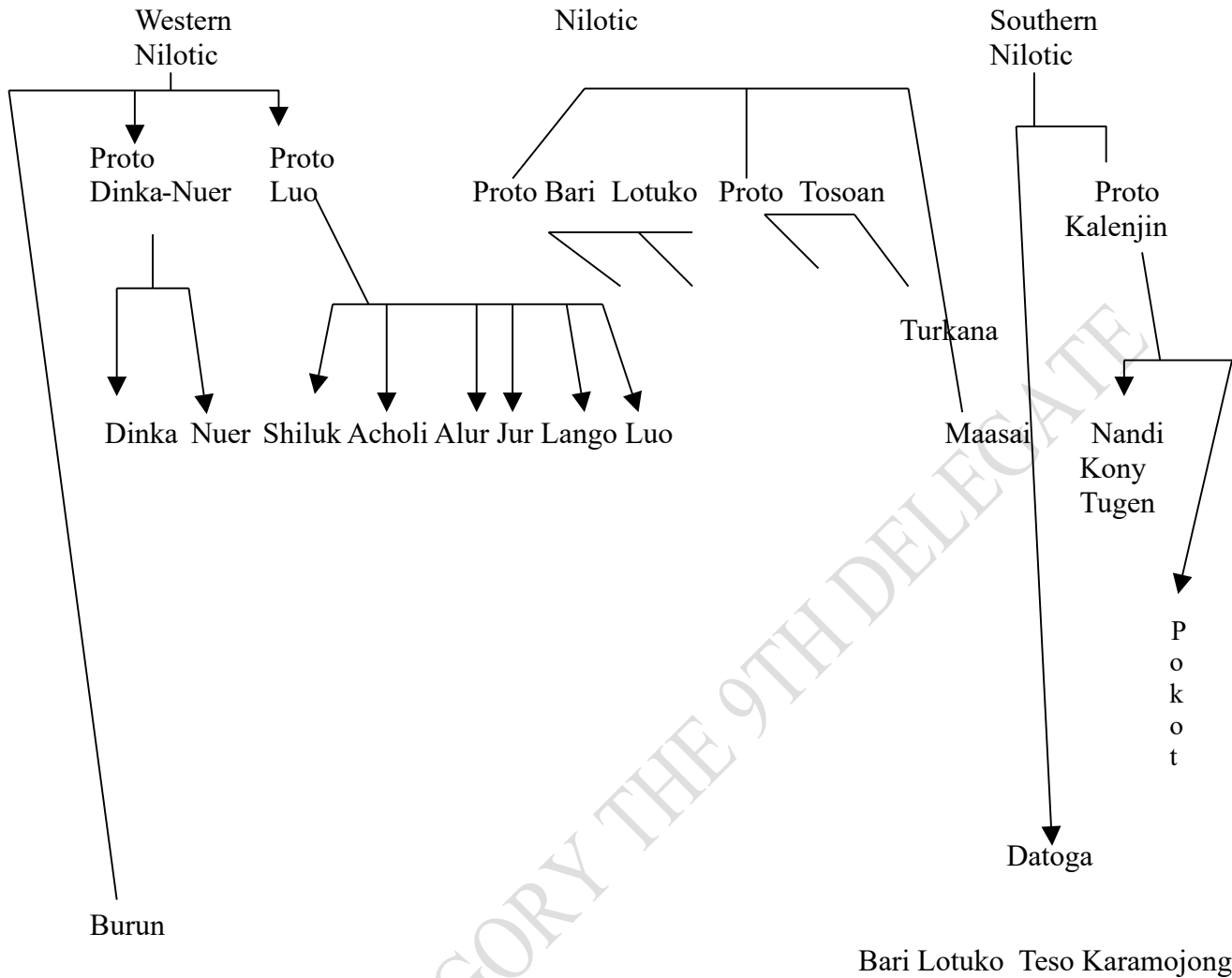
The chart below demonstrates how Ehret's language chart groups various Nilotic people.

A Descent Chart of Nilotic Languages



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Source: Hadith I P.120

Activity:

Which classificatory method could have been employed by Ehret?

All the language groups shown on the language chart are traceable to one ancestral or proto-Nilotic language. From a proto-Nilotic language, first dialects appeared which later developed into new languages. Ehret refers to such emergent languages as ‘daughter’ languages. Daughter languages gradually obtained their own dialects which developed into new daughter languages. As every daughter language developed a correspondingly new community speaking that language emerged.

Essentially, Ehret demonstrated that our River Lake, plains and Highland Nilotes in Kenya, as well as the Dinka-Nuer, Bari-Lotuko and Datoga communities were all one people in the distant past. The split which occurred was gradual but phenomenal. Hence as

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the above groups exist today, they have evolved various cultural peculiarities which distinctly differentiate them.

Note:

It is important to note that all Nilotic communities trace their ancestry from the proto-Nilotic languages. Some were Bantu or Cushitic speakers.

The Use of Words in Reconstructing People's History

A word is an important component in any language. This is because it is from individual words that a language is constituted. Hence words are vital sources in the reconstruction of peoples past relationships. Studies about African words and languages demonstrate how various ethnic groups related with one another over time. Two examples obtained from the possible cultural relationships between Western Bantu groups of Kenya and southern Nilotic Speakers will suffice.

Activity:

In which category did you encounter these words:

Eeri – Ancient Southern Nilotes Eeri

– Gusii

Eeyi – Abaluyia?

- a) The typological similarities existing among these words demonstrate that the three communities valued cattle keeping. But the time when they interacted differs as word borrowings indicate. Though it is not easy to assume who borrowed from who, going by inferences, one can reach some logical conclusions.

For instance, Ehret argues that during the proto Southern Nilotic period, 'eeri' underwent a sound change losing the 'r' to leave the new form of the word to be 'eei'. Secondly, therefore the Gusii word 'eeri' was borrowed from a very ancient Southern Nilotic language before the 'r' was dropped. Thirdly, the Abaluyia and even Bakisu borrowed 'eeyi' later after the 'loss' of the 'r'. This illustrates that both Abagusii and Abaluyia borrowed 'eeri' and 'eeyi' from the Southern Nilotic language showing that cultural influence and contact among these three communities existed.

- b) Age-set nomenclature is another example. According to Ehret, age-sets like koronkoro, Nyonki, Chuma and Sawe reveal some past relationship and interaction between Southern Nilotic speakers, Abakuria, Abaluyia and Kalenjin. While he argues that all the listed communities may have borrowed from Southern Nilotic speakers, Henry Mwanzi in his book A History of the Kipsigis disputes and suggests a Bantu origin.

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Whatever the origin, word similarity is a clear testimony of past interaction among all the above communities. None-the-less, when the interaction took place requires a person to consult several other factors before making final inferences.

Activity:

What are age-sets? How did Mwanzi in the above book or Alan Jacobs in Hadith I employ age-sets to write the history of the Kipsigis or the Maasai respectively?

Language Study About Bantu Origin and Expansion

Lwango-Luyingo and Jan Vansina in their article published in General History of Africa Vol. 3 estimate the Bantu as consisting of over 400 languages all deriving from the same 'proto Bantu'. Among all families, the word meaning 'people' is similar in root. Sample the following:-

<u>Community</u>	<u>Word for 'people'</u>
Shona	Vanhu
Duala	bato
Kongo	bantu
Bushong	baat
Swahili	Watu
Gusii	Abanto
Agikuyu	Andu
Abaluyia	Abandu

All derive from the form made up of the root 'ntu' and the prefix 'ba' denoting the plural. This nomenclature was coined by Wilhelm I. Bleek in 1862. The differences between some of these Bantu languages are regular as may be gathered from the comparison carried out among some of them.

Ever since Bleek branded the group 'Bantu', scholars have continued to puzzle over their origin and expansion. Harry H. Johnston's study published between 1919 and 1922 was the first attempt to locate the origin of the Bantu and plot the stages of their dispersal. He located the ancestors of the Bantu in the Bahr al Ghazal, not far from Bahr al Jebel to the east of Kordofan (in the Sudan) or in the Benue and Chad basins in the west. Their first movements as Johnstone argues, were eastwards towards Mt. Elgon and from there to the shores of Lake Victoria, Tanzania and Congo forests with the first large scale incursion into central and southern Africa beginning around 300BC.

Johnston's thesis influenced Mwanzi. Deriving from this thesis, Mwanzi argues that when communities both Bantu as well as Kalenjin with Bantu influence refer to a Misri origin, they may be referring to this north-south Bantu migration into East Africa.

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Two major theories on Bantu origin and migration were propounded by Joseph Greenberg and Malcolm Guthrie. Greenberg believed that the Bantu must have originated in the area of greatest divergence. And following this theory, he traced their origins to the middle Benue region of Nigeria. From there, Greenberg argued, they moved through the Congo forest to Central Africa, thence to Southern and Eastern Africa.

Activity:

Compare Harry Johnston's and Joseph Greenberg's theories on Bantu migration into East and South Africa. How do the two authorities differ?

Guthrie rejected Greenberg's view and located the most likely birthplace of proto-Bantu in the area of greatest convergence, around the watershed of the Congo and Zambezi rivers with a nucleus in the Shaba province of Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC). In challenging Greenberg, Guthrie wondered how large numbers of Bantu migrants could have traversed the inhospitable and impenetrable forest between the area encompassed by the Ubangi and Congo rivers as well as the Atlantic Ocean.

The historian Roland Oliver endeavoured to reconcile these two linguistics. He pointed out that Guthrie's findings do not fundamentally contradict Greenberg's outcome. Instead, Guthrie modifies Greenberg's simple hypothesis in a very important way. Consequently, Oliver suggests that the Bantu originated from the Savana region of Nigeria, crossed the forest to Central Africa where they found the vegetation and the climate to be the same as they were used to. So they settled down. From here the second dispersal took place and saw the Bantu occupy the East, Central and South Africa gradually.

Yet that reconciliation did not stem the urge to resolve this Bantu question. Since 1973, three groups of linguists working independently have arguably faulted Guthrie. All the three adopted a similar approach (based on studies of vocabulary) but they did not use the same data. Hence the Bantu question still continues puzzling both linguists and historians. The conflicting postulations about the birthplace of Bantu speakers suggest the inconclusiveness inherent in linguistic evidence. There is therefore need to harness other sources in an endeavour to unravel the Bantu question firmly.

Activity:

Is it true that all current Bantu speakers originated from one and the same place in West Africa? Give reasons for your answer.

Chronology and Historical Linguistics

Linguistic technique employed in dating is known as glottochronology. This is relative chronology as opposed to an absolute one. Linguists can only say that event 'A' occurred before event 'B'. But they cannot say that event 'A' occurred in the seventh or twelfth century.

Activity:

Does this illustration help you distinguish between relative and absolute chronology?

Absolute dating is employed by historical linguists as a result of applying archaeological dating methods. For instance, in reconstructing vocabularies of proto-languages which are evidence of material culture revealed by archaeology, linguists borrow archaeological dating in determining when those proto-languages existed. In 1962 an archaeologist Merrick Posnansky suggested that the migration of Bantu peoples from West Africa to Central Africa involved agricultural communities and that the movement gathered momentum after the agricultural techniques (banana and yam cultivation) introduced by the Indonesians between 400BC and 200AD spread to the forest peoples of Central Africa. This is an instant where archaeology assists linguists in providing absolute dates.

Note:

It is important to note that Historical linguistics has enabled us to study cultural relationships which existed among various African communities.

3.4 Summary

In this lesson we have seen that historical linguistics can be applied to reconstruct the history of African communities. Employing techniques of historical linguistics peoples cultural relationships, interactions and migrations are explained. Specific cases of Nilotic and Bantu speakers have been discussed. Finally we have seen that for historical linguistics to provide absolute dates, it has to liaise with other disciplines such as archaeology.

Activity:

To what extent has historical linguistics facilitated the writing of any African community's history?

Illustrate your answer.

3.5 Definition of Key Words

Absolute Chronology:	This is a technique of dating which gives precise dates.
Genetic Classification:	This is a manner in which language are classified as if they contain genes which can be grouped together.
Glottochronology:	Refers to a linguistic technique employed in dating.
Historical Linguistics:	Refers to the scientific study of language changes over time.
Language:	Is a pattern of conventional symbols which bring about communication.

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Proto: Is used in combinations with other words. In linguistics it refers to ancestral or original.
Proto-Bantu or proto-Nilotic refers to ancestral Bantu or ancestral Nilotic speakers, respectively.

Relative Chronology: Is used when no absolute or precise dates are available.

Typological Classification: Refers to a linguistic process that classifies or groups language purely on structural bases.

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Note: *The original UNESCO publications are useful but rare to find in ordinary bookshops.

LESSON FOUR: WRITTEN SOURCES

4.1 Introduction

In lesson three we discussed how historical linguistics is a useful source of African history. We looked at various classifications, importance of words in the reconstruction of African history and the origin and expansion of Bantu speakers. We saw that linguistics uses relative dating and can apply definite dates only with the help of other sources such as archaeology.

Our discussion of written sources will provide a survey of the various forms of literature including ancient, Asiatic, European and African. We hope in the process to demonstrate that if used carefully, written sources are crucial in the reconstruction of African history.

4.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson you should be able to:

- (1) Illustrate the existence of written documents in the Ancient Africa.
- (2) Identify and apply various types of written sources in the reconstruction of African history.

4.3 Content

Written records are the most common sources of history available to us today. These records stretch as far back as the period of ancient Egyptians, Greeks and Romans and became more popular with the European penetration of our continent.

(a) Ancient Evidence

Ancient evidence as a concept refers to the classical period. This is the period which stretches from the time before Christ to roughly about the arrival of Arabs into Africa in the 7th Century of the Christian era. During this lifespan a lot of both archaeological and literary evidence can be harnessed in the reconstruction of African past.

The ancient period is crucial because it provides evidence demonstrating the importance of Africa in influencing global civilization. Archaeologically, there is proof that the cultures of lower Nile, Egypt proper were initially derived from the Neolithic cultures which first took shape in the then green Sahara of the 5000 BC. Before reaching the green Sahara, these cultures existed in the land of the Great Lakes in East Africa. That is where we have evidence of the earliest human beings ever.

It is therefore from mankind's cradleland in East Africa that global cultures spread to other parts of the world. Available classical written documents support the antiquity of

life in Africa. For instance Diodorus Sikeliotes of Sicily wrote in 50 BC that the black people were the first of all humankind to come into existence.

Diodorus stated that Egyptian cultures and Egyptians themselves came from the south – the land of Ethiopians. Martin Bernal in his book The Black Athena Vol. I supports this view. He argues that the Afroasiatic people moved from the Rift Valley well equipped with hippopotamus hunting tools (harpoons). They also possessed domesticated food crops and cattle. Going through the Savanna the Chadic speakers reached Lake Chad, the Berbers the Maghrib and the Proto Egyptians, Upper Egypt. Speakers of Proto-Semitic settled in Ethiopia and moved on to the Arabian Savanna.

Activity:

Draw a map of Africa and sketch the migratory routes of the ancient people as argued out by Martin Bernal.

Egypt in the ancient times stands out as a significant centre of civilization. Information gathered by Manetho, an Egyptian historian in the third century before the Christian era provides us with a solid framework of Egyptian history. Manetho was appointed by ptolemaic kings to be in charge of writing their history. The thirty-one manethonian dynasties remain today the firm foundation of relative chronology of Egypt. Manethonian writing was in hieroglyphic, hieratic and demotic. This Egyptian literary sources were often prepared to enumerate a pharaoh's achievements or ensure eternal worship.

Two surviving forms demonstrate the above argument:

(i) The Palermo Stone is a diorite slab carved on both faces. The slab contains names of all the Pharaohs who reigned in Egypt from the beginning to the fifth dynasty around 2400 BC. Starting with the third dynasty, the Palermo stone lists not only the names of rulers in the order of their succession, but also year by year, the most important events of his reign. This stone is preserved at Palermo city in Sicily.

(ii) The Turin Papyrus is the second form. It is preserved in the Museum of Turin in Italy. Turin papyrus consists only of a list of rulers with their complete protocol as well as the number of years, months and days of the reigns arranged in chronological order. The papyrus provides a complete list of all the Pharaohs from the earliest times to around 1200 BC. The cultures which started in the Great Lakes of East Africa find their fulfilment in the Great Civilization of Egypt. From Egypt this civilization reached other continents especially Europe through Greece.

Note:

G. Mokhtar in General History of Africa Vol II characterises occupants of ancient Egypt as having black and curly hair, round and hairless

face, and in the Old Kingdom they sometimes
tamed moustache

Herodotus writings and those of later Greek writers demonstrate that there were widespread conquests by an Egyptian Pharaoh Sesostrius who has in recent times been identified with Senwosret, one of a number of the 12th dynasty Pharaohs. Similar conquests were also carried out by another Pharaoh of the 12th dynasty known as Ammenemes II. This information is also contained on the inscriptions from Memphis.

The inscriptions detail conquests by land and sea of two 12th dynasty Pharaohs Senwosret I and Ammenemes II. Thus it is probable that through such conquests, the Egyptians were able to spread their values, including pyramidal architecture into the ancient Greece.

Herodotus wrote that nearly all names of Greek gods came from Egypt. Bernal demonstrates his support by arguing that Athens or Athena derives from the divine Egyptian Ht Nt (Temple or House of goddess Neit). In antiquity, Athena was identified with the Egyptian goddess Nt or Neit. Both were divinities of warfare, weaving and wisdom.

Egypt also trained Greek thinkers, scientists, philosophers and mathematicians. They include leading mathematicians like Pythagorus, Eudoxus and Euclid. Aristotle wrote that Egypt was the cradle of mathematics. This is supported by the accuracy manifested in the building of Egyptian pyramids and temples. They were built by mathematical propositions which the Egyptians had discovered and proven.

Furthermore, Aristotle, Isokrates, Anaxoras and Plato were influenced by Egyptian philosophy. They learnt in Egypt and imbibed from their certain values that contrasted with Greek culture. Hence the Greek authorities indicted them on return charging them with introducing foreign divinities.

Activity:

What do ancient written records illustrate about
Egyptian history?

Discussions on the Maghrib are contained in various works of historians and geographers. They mainly discuss activities of Phoenicians in Carthage. Works such as Periplus of Hano tackle the trading activities at the Coast of Morocco.

St. Augustine of Hippo (354 to 430AD) and his contemporaries illustrate the Maghrib relations with the Christian Community. His intensity of experience and his lyricism make him timeless. Through the City of God and Confessions Augustine explains religious issues and presents optimism to those who endure.

Activity:

If possible borrow St. Augustines The City of God and
review his thought.

Concerning knowledge on the ancient areas of the Horn of Africa upto East African Coast, The Periplus of the Erythrean Sea written by a Greek speaking Egyptian around 120 AD is handy. The text describes the Red Sea and the Gulf of Oman, Berbera, Cape Guardafui and Olok. The author who is sometimes described as anonymous, or given a name like Basiles by Eric Aseka in Themes in Kenyan History or Flavius Arrianus by Luc Croegaert in The African continent noted the existence of the Port of Adulis, the obligatory transit point for merchandise imported from India, Egypt and Rome as well as outlet for the production of the Kingdom of Aksum.

The document reveals that Indian vessels brought wheat, rice, sugar, cotton and spices. Merchandise from Italy and the north consisted of olive oil, fabrics, tin, copper, worked and unworked silver while Egypt furnished cotton and blankets. Through Adulis, Aksum exported slaves captured during wars, ivory, gold, incense, perfumes, tortoise shells, rhinoceros horns and hippopotamus skins. Numerous currency remains from Greece, India, Persia, Rome and Byzantine testify to the expanse of this commerce.

Note:

It is important to note that there was regular commercial traffic along the Coast of Indian Ocean long before the Muslim conquests.

Claudius Ptolemy (90-168 AD), an Egyptian gathered and systematized the first epigraphical and literary documents into A Guide to Geography around 140AD. The book was in seven volumes with maps, commentaries and an index. For a dozen years it remained the basic monumental guide to navigators. Ptolemy's work was translated into Arabic in the 9th C. AD, into Latin in 1409 AD as well as in the Greek original in 1533 AD.

Ptolemy believed that the earth was round and that it was the centre of the universe, an opinion which prevailed until the Copernican revolution. He was also the first to have invented the notion and terms of 'longitude' and 'latitude'. However, he was not able to situate the equator correctly. On his maps Asia extends much farther to the East than is actually the case.

Note:

It is important to note that this error encouraged Christopher Columbus (1451-1506) to sail to the West and ended by finding the 'New World'.

Activity:

Discuss the role of Ancient records in the reconstruction of African history.

c) Asiatic Sources

Asiatic sources include Arabic, Chinese, Indian and other sources found on the Asian continent. Of them all Arabic sources are more dominant in our circles. We will

therefore employ Arabic as well as Chinese sources to demonstrate their contribution in the reconstruction of African history.

(i) Arabic Sources

The notion of Arabic sources is taken to signify sources written in Arabic language either by Arab authors or by authors from other backgrounds but writing in Arabic language. Such other authors were drawn from Europe or Africa, especially in the northern and Maghrib parts.

Arabic materials are mainly available for the Muslims and predominantly Muslim areas of Africa. Included are areas north of the tenth degree of latitude and along the East African Coast down to the borders of Mozambique.

In North Africa Islamic influence is felt from mid 7th C. AD while in East West Africa from about the tenth century AD. Information employed by Arabic sources came from different sources, written as well as oral. In discussing these sources, it is convenient to sub-divide this topic into two broad periods.

The First Islamic Age 650-1050 AD

During this period there was scanty of information. Besides, the information was more general in character being derived from vanished works cited by later authors. But towards the end of the period, the information increased in scope and specificity.

For instance the Yemenian Wahb ibn Munabbith (729 or 732) left a brief list of the East African nations such as Nubians, Habashas or Abyssinians, Barbarians of Somaliland and the Zanj or the East African Bantu people. Another useful source is the Tarikh series. The Tarikh of Khalifa B. Khayyat is one of the oldest Arabic annals which contains essential information on the conquest of Maghrib.

Al Tabari reproduces in his Tarikh one of the oldest Arabic accounts of the black world through the testimony of the historiographer Umar B. Shabba. This testimony relates to the revolt of the Sudan at Medina in 145 AH (762 AD) and bears witness to the considerable presence of Africans at the height of the period.

Arabic sources during this period discussed the state of Ghana which was famous for its gold and the Zanj country. Other works wrote about Nubia, Ethiopia, the Sudan, the Beja, the Zanj and Zaghawa of Kanem. Others still highlighted trans-Saharan trade routes such as the one linking Ghana to Egypt. The particular route crossed Kuku (Gao) South Air and the Egyptian Oases.

Al Majid reported in 918 AD his crossing of the Persian Gulf to Kilwa by the 'Sea of Zanj' in his book Muruj adh dhahab (The Meadows of Gold). He seems to have reached Beira, Sofala, and perhaps Madagascar. In the book Masud marvels at the prodigious

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production of gold of these regions. He has detailed the abundance of food such as bananas, peanuts, meat, honey and cocoa nuts.

Towards the end of this first Islamic age, in 988 AD, the geographer Ibn Hawqal (Hawkal) finished his book the Masalik (configurations of the Earth) covering the Islamic world of the time. He described Sijilmasa, an important commercial post south of the Maghrib, with its well cultivated crops and its numerous and healthy population living well from the revenues of trans Saharan trade which exchanged salt from the north for gold from the south. Ibn Hawqal probably descended to Audaghust where the prince maintained regular relations with the ruler of Ghana. Hawqal also travelled to Nubia and adjoining regions

The Second Islamic Age: since 1050 AD

During this period more Arabic works emerged. Contents were comparatively more detailed than what appeared in the first age. In the 11th C. AD (1068) a Spanish author Al Bakri described in his work, The Book of Roads and Kingdoms the region of Ghana, the 'King of Blacks'. The ruler was respected like a god. In his presence, people knelt and threw dust over their heads. At his death he was buried in a mausoleum situated in a sacred grove and his servants were buried alive with him to be at his disposition in the afterlife.

Note:

It is important to note that the book of Al Bakri is still resourceful in understanding of the middle ages of West Africa.

Al-Idrisi (1100-1166) though born in Morocco, lived in Palermo at the Court of Roger II, King of Sicily (1101-1154). In his work, The Book of Roger (1154). Idrisi gives a general geography and an atlas of particular maps and commentary-like text on them. The work provides a great amount of new information from West African countries such as Tekrur, Ghana, Kuku as well as East Africa. He cites the fabulous resources in gold and astonishing luxury of the royal court in the Kingdom of Ghana. However, he commits some major geographical errors. For instance, Idrisi alleged that the Niger comes from the east, is a branch of the Nile and flows to the west into the Atlantic ocean.

Activity:

Rectify Al-Idrisi's errors and draw a sketch map showing the courses of the two rivers.

Ibn Battuta provides an invaluable first hand account of his observations. He travelled along the East African coast as far as Kilwa in 1329. Battuta reported that Kilwa was a very important and active port and so rich that it could permit itself to coin its own money. He crossed the Mauritania desert in 1352 AD, reached the capital of Old Kingdom of Mali and returned to North Africa via Timbuctu, Gao and the central Sahara. His descriptions give us a vivid picture of the Mali empire at the height of its power.

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The second half of the 14th C AD witnessed the activity of the African Arabic historian Ibn Khaldun (1332-1406). Born in Tunis where he studied thoroughly all the disciplines offered in his time, Khaldun served under numerous regimes with equal ease. In his book Universal History after recommending the critical spirit that has to be used in the interpretation of historical sources, he himself took pains to search for a logical and rational relations beyond the multitude of events from which one could deduce laws. He analysed the phenomena of birth, development and decline of empires and stressed the fundamental importance of social relations, determined by the modes of production, and in their turn determining the forms of government.

Khaldun found the driving principle of historical development in the dialectical analysis between the behaviour of the nomads who were obliged to defend themselves and the sedentary population. The latter group were installed in cities and ceded their power to a chief who would become a dictator.

Other useful Arabic sources include Mahmud Kati's Tarikh el Fattash (Chronicles of the Searcher) in Timbuctu. Kati recounts with much detail his pilgrimage to Mecca. The text, a work of three generations concerning the history of Songhay and adjoining nations such as Morocco commenced its coverage from 1519 to 1591. In the text, Mahmoud Bagayogo condemned Askiya Ishaq of Gao for his oppression and extortionate character.

Al Said's Tarikh al Sudan (Chronicle of the Western Sudan.) (1596) speaks of Ghana and the foundation of Djenné. All these Arabic works and many more are very important in the writing of African history especially in the Maghrib, North Africa as well as the Islamic parts of the other regions of Africa.

Activity:

Examine the contribution of Arabic sources in the reconstruction of West African history before 1500 AD.

ii) Chinese Documents

These records constitute the second component of Asiatic sources. But unlike Arabic scripts, they are not as widespread. Consequently, we will use them specifically to illustrate their importance in reconstructing East African history. Some of the historical records of relevance to the African history were compiled during T'ang, Sung and Ming dynasties. Their contents cover over 800 years.

Note:

You should note that primary sources of Chinese knowledge about East Africa during T'ang dynasty (618-907 AD) come from Ching Hsing Chi (Records of Travels). During the Sung dynasty (960-1279 AD) information is in Chu-Fan-Chih (Ghazetteer of Foreigners) and Ling-Wai Tai ta (Information from Beyond the

Mountain). Records of the Ming (1368-1644) are in Wu-Pei-Chih (Notes on Military Preparedness) Hsing-Ch'a Sheng-Lan (Triumphant Vision of the Stary Raft) and Ming Shih (History of the Ming Dynasty).

These documents in the imperial archives serve as the basis of Chinese understanding of East Africa. Except for Hsing Ch'a Sheng Lan (Triumphant Vision of the Stary Raft) written by Fei Hsin in 1436, other works were compiled by court scholars who relied on Chinese travellers or Arab traders who were major traders in the Indian ocean. During Ming dynasty a court eunuch Ching Ho led seven imperial expeditions during the period of 1405 and 1433 AD which brought about the first direct official contact between China and East Africa.

However, all official records about Ching Ho's extraordinary voyages were destroyed. As a result, his expeditions are found in the works of Ma Huan, a member of the scholar class who served as a junior officer on some of Cheng Ho's voyages.

G.S.P Freeman-Grenville, Wheatley and Gervase Mathews have employed Chinese sources to discuss the history of East African people. Mathews used Chinese documents to highlight the importation of ivory, rhinoceros horns, tortoise shells and embergri. He also concedes that Chinese geographers had a detailed knowledge of Po- pa-li, a country on the western sea, and had heard of customs of the black inhabitants of Mo lin. Nonetheless, Mathews qualifies the Chinese accounts as probably hearsay, gathered in India or Indonesia.

Chinese sources provided us with an insight to the Chinese images of East Africa. They assumed that East Africans lacked 'good morals' and used the misguided assumption to condescend towards East African slaves. Additionally, sinocentrism culminated in China's self adulation when the ruler of Malindi sent an emissary with a giraffe to the Ming emperor via Cheng Ho's imperial fleet in 1419.

Why a giraffe? The word giraffe in the Somali language is "girin" which is very close to Ki-lin in Chinese. Ki-lin happens to be an animal in Chinese mythology that appears only during times of peace and harmony. It symbolizes Heavens favour upon the virtue of the emperor, the ruler of the entire world. By offering a giraffe, the ruler of Malindi unwittingly conformed to the category of a tributary state, recognizing the dominion of the Ming emperor.

As a result of the strong ethnic chauvinism toward the outside world, Chinese sources often describe East Africans in an unfavourable light. Since most East Africans were brought to China as slaves they often received derogatory appellations, including 'wild men', 'devil-slaves' and 'black servants'. These descriptions of East Africans reveal a racial hierarchy in the Chinese world-view resembling the European theory of racial hierarchy in the 19th C. This feeling still persists in some parts of the Chinese community. In the late 1980s, the Kenyan press reported racial conflicts between African students

studying in China and their Chinese counterparts who were resisting against Chinese girls having relationships with African men.

Chinese historical documents have the potential to confirm findings from other sources such as Arabic accounts of the coast, archaeological evidence or oral traditions. For instance, Al-Idrisi (1100-1166) recorded that Arab merchants lured children of Zanj with dates in order to enslave them. Consequently, Ling-Wai Tai ta (Information From Beyond the Mountains) (1163) also recorded the enslavement of black people through the enticements of food. The verification provided by this Chinese documentation strengthens the case for this particular fact of enslavement during the twelfth century.

4.4 Summary

In this lesson we have learnt about the importance of ancient evidence in demonstrating the antiquity of life in Africa as well as African contribution to world civilization. This evidence has come from written sources by ancient Egyptians, Greeks and Romans among others. Furthermore, we have examined the contribution of Asiatic sources especially Chinese and Arabic written sources in shedding light on the activities which took place in Africa. Our concern has been to illustrate that Africa was linked to the outside world through various social, economic and political activities.

Activity:

What do we learn from the Chinese records about East Africa? Explain your answer.

4.5 Definition of Key Words

Ancient period – Refers to the period beginning in the before Christ to the advent of Arabs at around 7th AD.

Hieroglyphic, Hieratic and Demotic – Are forms of writing which Ancient Egyptians used . While Hieroglyphic is more crude, Hieratic is somewhat refined and Demotic is the most refined and cursive form.

4.6 Further Reading

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LESSON FIVE

5.0 EUROPEAN DOCUMENTS

5.1 Introduction

In lesson four we learnt about some aspects of the written sources. In particular we tackled Ancient Evidence and Asiatic sources aiming at demonstrating that even before Europeans arrived in Africa some written records were in practice. We showed that both Africans and non-Africans such as Greeks, Romans and Arabs wrote about various aspects of the African society of the ancient and medieval eras.

This lesson continues discussing written records by concentrating on European and African written sources. We hope to show that Europeans and African sources have some contribution to make towards African history if well used.

5.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- (1) Analyse the importance of both European and African written sources in the reconstruction of African history.

5.3 Content

European documents are materials collected and written as articles, monographs, letters, diaries, maps, research papers, newspapers and magazines or published in book forms by Europeans. Europeans involved were from various fields of interest including explorers, missionaries, traders, colonialists and imperialists, journalists as well as researchers. Besides they came from different countries such as Britain, France, Germany, Portugal, Spain, Holland, Italy, Russia and Belgium. The presence of Scandinavian countries is increasingly felt. United States of America (USA) is also discussed under this broader category.

European documents were written in various European languages, each language reflecting the nationality of its authors. The most prevalent European languages in the documents include English, French, Portuguese, Spanish, Latin, German, Dutch and Russian. The documents generally reflected the ideological interests of their mother countries on the one hand, or the interests of their specialities on the other. For instance, documents by missionaries reflect their concern with religious issues while those by explorers contained information on land terrain and features such as mountains, rivers and lakes.

a) European Documents Between 16th and 18th Centuries

The period between 16th and 18th centuries is characterized by the fact that most European documents covered mainly the coastal areas of Africa. European information on

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the African coastal areas were intimate and specialized. Yet almost nothing was known through direct contact with the far interior of Africa.

Note:

You should note that this ignorance about the the interior was not unique to Africa. This is because during the same period very little was known about the interior of North or South America, and even Central Asia.

Bearing the note in mind, we can agree with Philip Curtin's view that the image of 'darkest' Africa either as an expression of geographical ignorance or as one of cultural arrogance, was a 19th century invention.

European documents contained information on slave trade, geography, ethnology and European adventures. In the 16th C. there was a substantial increase in the number of accounts by European travellers and contemporary witness in North Africa. The accounts were against Islam, because the writers were influenced by Christian backgrounds. For instance, Miguel Cervantes, a Frenchman praised Napoleon's mission in Egypt, a country with a Muslim predominance.

In the 16th C the first direct European reports about West Africa appeared. The first reports were made by the Portuguese who were later followed by other Europeans. Some of these documents covered coastal regions in Senegal, Mauritania, Sierra Leone, Dahomey and French Guinea (the present day Republic of Guinea).

Ethiopia also drew a lot of attention from Europeans. This stemmed from a European belief about existence of a Christian Prince Prestor John in Ethiopia. Consequently, in the 16th C the Monk Bahrey, an eye-witness of the Oromo invasion of Ethiopia wrote a book titled The History of Galla. In addition, another title on the general histories of Ethiopia was written by Hiab Ludolf. The latter was the founder of Ethiopian studies in Europe. Thus, the curiosity which spurred Europeans to go to Ethiopia resulted in many documents being published on Ethiopia. Europeans who were interested included Russians, Czechs, Swedes, British and Americans.

There were European documents about South Africa dating from the 16th C. They were written by the Dutch sailors and settlers from the Cape region. Beginning from the second half of the 18th C, documents about the interior of South Africa emerged. Cases in point include John Philip who devoted his life writing in defense of African rights as he felt them at that time. More documents were written about the San, Nama and Herero of Namibia though the manner in which the communities were depicted was as if they were objects of curiosity.

Apart from documents which covered only specific regions like North Africa, West Africa and South Africa, others existed with a wider coverage. Such documents included Thomas Astley's New General Collection of Voyages and Travels which was compiled and

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produced between 1745 and 1747 AD. A quarter of the volume was devoted to Africa. The publication comprising both French and English works and accounts omitted tales of adventure and stressed on geographic and ethnographic information. All authorities on any section of the Coast were brought together, reprinted in their own words where possible and supplied with connecting passages to present comprehensive accounts.

Another collection titled Universal History comprising about sixty volumes designed to be an epitome of world history and geography, was prepared and published between 1736 and 1765. Two volumes devoted to Africa included individual countries' short sketches of European activities. However, the main thrust was about the history, manners and customs of the Africans themselves.

European travellers wrote to please the audience and sponsors. As Philip Curtin states, religious beliefs were of no interest. Such beliefs were considered pagan errors while spectacular festivals, judicial ordeals and polygyny were curiosities which were recounted at length. Furthermore, the reporting stressed precisely those aspects of African life that were most repellent to the West and tended to submerge the indications of a common humanity.

b) European Documents From the 19th Century to the 1960s

The demarcation of the period from the earlier one is flexible. Some issues which were raised in the previous era continued into and even beyond this one. However, unlike in the earlier epoch, more European documents covered various areas and features of the interior of Africa. Furthermore, this era was characterized by colonialism on the African continent. Hence, colonial settlers, administrators and their agents were resident on the continent for a longer period. This longer period enabled them to write more information about Africa and the Africans.

Information about African political units, drainage systems, mountains and other socio-economic activities of the continent was produced in abundance during this era. 19th C explorers alleged that the great Zimbabwe was constructed by the Phoenician gold traders of the Millennium before Christ. In 1961, however, Roland Oliver in The Dawn of African History refuted the claim arguing that Zimbabwe, Monomotapa, Ankole and Rwanda were established by people from the north.

Oliver stated that the migrants from the north were 'Hamites' and Nilotes. But researches from the late 1960s into the 1990s by such scholars as Edith R Sanders who wrote 'The Hamitic Hypothesis and Functions in time Perspective' published in Journal of African History Vol.X, 4, 1969 and Archie Mafeje in his book The Theory and Ethnography of Africa's social Formation published in 1991 have demonstrated that all these empires were established by the various Bantu communities who inhabited the respective areas. Indeed, Croegaert grounds the concept of "Zimbabwe" among the Shona who used the term in referring to fortified royal residences.

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Cheikh anta Diop in his African Civilization: Myth or Reality? Published in 1974 emphasized that the Hamitic myth was a mere racist and arrogant European way of classifying Africans. It is to be pointed out that even as we were approaching the 21st century, racism still persisted and some whites continued using such terms as 'hamites' or 'Nilo-hamites' in reference to various African peoples in blatant disregard of the already established facts. Smith Hempstone, former US ambassador to Kenya between 1989 and 1993 is a case in point. In his book, The Rogue Ambassador published in 1997, Hempstone derogatorily refers to the Turkana, Karamojong, Taposi and Maasai as Nilo- Hamites yet it is common knowledge that having stayed in Kenya for a very long time and interacted with Kenyan scholars, historians included, he could have known that such pejorative terms were not accommodated by Africans.

In 1830 Roland and John Lander explored river Niger upto the Oil River delta and ended up settling the Niger question which had puzzled many earlier explorers and geographers. In 1858, through the effort of John Speke and Richard Burton, the source of the River Nile was explored. Similar efforts by explorer missionaries such as Ludwig Krapf and John Rebman resulted in the exploration and records about mounts Kenya and Kilimanjaro, respectively.

We suspect that initially Mounts Kenya and Kilimanjaro were known to the local communities by different names. But due to the power of the written word, the current names, though initially faulty, have come to be applied instead of the earlier ones. For instance, Kwesi Prah has cited Anold Temu in arguing that the Chagga living around Mount Kilimanjaro knew it as 'Njara'. It is probable, therefore, that 'Kilima' a Kiswahili term for mountain was mistaken by Rebman for part of the name of the mountain. Hence 'kilima Njara' among the Chagga simply meant 'the mountain known as Njara'.

Results of the exploration led to cartographers drawing new maps, correcting earlier errors made by their predecessors. In the process of these explorations, Europeans commented also on the people, their cultures and their economic life. But the greatest reports on the African communities were written by colonial administrators, settlers, missionaries and anthropologists. Journalists reports are also useful. In 1950s, European journalists applied their profession to expose colonial brutality meted out to Africans whether or not the victims were genuine Mau Mau sympathizers. B.A. Ogot in his Building on the Indigenous which came out in 1999 makes good use of such articles in the book.

Activity:

Select any text, especially written by European explorers, settlers and administrators and analyse their attitude towards Africans living in Africa.

(c) Usefulness of European Documents

European documents, however misconstrued, laid much of the foundation of our systematic knowledge of African society. Firstly, they contribute to our chronological

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framework because dates written down by explorers, missionaries and administrators guide us in our ordering of events.

Secondly, European documents provide materials to us for the reconstruction of economic history. Information contained in these documents enable history students to identify specific trade routes, markets, commodities and prices, natural resources and craft products which were exchanged at particular periods. Besides, the information enabled history practitioners to determine communities who were involved in the exchange and the method of exchange.

Thirdly, the documents make known indigenous African practices i.e. African rituals, production techniques, war strategies and tactics. Prudent use of data is required when one employs these documents so as not to take in a faculty view without subjecting it to various cross-examinations with other documents and sources.

Lastly, maps which were drawn in the 16th century guide history practitioners in following up developments of place names. Such maps indicated names of localities which have now disappeared or only exist in oral tradition. An example is Shungwaya along the Indian Ocean. Maps also provide information on the distribution of ethnic groups, boundaries between states, names of rivers and mountains. All these have historical importance.

European documents are best applied in collaboration with other sources. A skillful blend of European documentary sources with those of oral tradition and other sources will yield balanced information. Such approach minimizes the degree of error in historical reconstruction.

Note:

You should note, however, that European documents in independent Africa are not as racist as those in the colonial era. Authors like Jan Vansina, Terrance Ranger, Roland Oliver and Basil Davidson are characterized as Africanists because of their largely pro-African inclination.

Nonetheless, there still exist Europeans who hold racist views. Justin Wills' article in Ethnicity, Nationalism and Democracy which claimed that European missionaries invented a people called Bondei who subsequently began to acquire their own distinct history in Tanzania is an example. We know that before the arrival of Europeans in Tanganyika, the Bondei existed. Willis himself attests to this in his article.

The authors of the Bell Curves are yet another category of racist writers. They alleged that while average IQ for whites is 100, for African Americans it is about 80 and for Africans about 75. All black people, according to these authors are slightly ahead of mentally retarded whites.

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Philippe Rushton is reported in Tiyaambe Zeleza's Manufacturing African Studies and Crises as alleging that Africans are the least intelligent, most aggressive and over-sexed of all races hence the assumed prevalence of AIDS in Africa and among the blacks in the Diaspora. But looking at sex scandals against some American politicians in the late 1990s, the reading and viewing public established that matters of sexual waywardness could not probably be a preserve of Africans and their descendants in the diaspora.

The preceding examples clearly show racism. Therefore, caution should be exercised when applying European documents of whatever period. Any laxity can lead one to reconstruct a distorted history of our past.

Activity:

Identify any document written by a European or Europeans and assess its contribution to the writing of African history.

d) African Written Sources

These are documents written by authors whose homes are on the African continent. Consequently they may be black or Semitic people in ancestry. Of importance is that through their literature the outside world gets to learn about the social, economic and political aspect of the African continent. Initially, especially in the pre 1500AD, African written sources were found largely in the Maghrib, North Africa, Western Sudan, the Horn of Africa and East African Coast.

African languages employed in conveying the greatest mass of information include ancient Egyptian, Berber, Ethiopian languages, Coptic, Kiswahili, Hausa and Fulfude. Chronologically, the first written sources were the Egyptian scripts in hieroglyphs, hieratic and demotic. Hieratic Egyptian papyri date from the New Kingdom perhaps as far back as the Pharaonic Middle Kingdom at the beginning of the second millennium before the Christian era. Djait H.'s article in General History of Africa Vol. I cites the papyrus known as 'Instructions for King Merikere' as an example.

In the New Kingdom, the papyri and ostraca (Limestone tablet) served as paper. Later, demotic form of writing, a more refined form emerged. Later, records appear in coptic language but using Greek scripts emerged and are available in archives. Ethiopian writing, on the other hand is rather recent and dates from the 13thC AD. These early Egyptian and Ethiopian records covered both governmental and private matters on administration, accountancy, private letters, stories and novels.

Note:

You should note that other African written sources were discussed under ancient evidence and Asiatic sources. They include works of Ibn Battuta, Ibn Khaldun and St. Augustine. Also the Tarikh series by various authors were discussed.

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Documents along the East African coast were written in Kiswahili but in Arabic scripts. Most of these writings emerged in the previous century. However, more of the African writings were produced in the post 1500AD.

The Kitab al Sulwa Fi akhbar (The Book of Consolation of the History of Kilwa) written between 1520 and 1530 is the earliest known history. This history traces Kilwa's foundation from the tenth century. More accounts were written in the 17th and 18th centuries. The works covered especially Maghrib, Sahel and Tropical forest regions. Scholars produced works devoted to local chronicles, clan genealogies, biographies and religious issues.

For example Kitab al Ghunja written by Al Mustafa in 1751-2 traces Gonja's development supplying information on past imams and other Muslim functions to the rulers. The book which has annals of local occurrences arranged chronologically covers wars, families, and death. It was updated in 1765 and the 1960s. Islamic influence could have been manifested in the writings of most of those African writers who employed Arabic language.

Kitab al Ghunja's negative obituary on Opoku Ware may serve as an example. The obituary unusually celebrated his demise claiming that his reign was packed with oppression, robberies, and fear throughout his long regime. The author in fact started the obituary by wishing Opoku curses and perdition in hell. Certainly, the arbitrary adopted a rare tone given that very often we wish the dead eternal peace rather than condemnation. Possibly this harshness and ill-will may be due to Opoku Ware's non- Muslim faith.

African writings in European languages emerged in the 18th C. Fante writers from the coastal region of present day Ghana including Jacobus Capitein and A. Willen Amo paved the way for major works written by liberated slaves such as Ignatius Sancho who was born on a slave ship in West Indies, Ottobah Cuguano, a Fante of Gold Coast, and Olanda Equiano an Ibo of Nigeria. These writers were advocates of the abolition of slave trade. They also provided materials on the life's of black people in black Africa and Europe.

The paucity of Africa written sources between the 16th and 18th C is evident in Southern Africa, Central Africa and the interior of the continent South of the Sahara. But from the 19th C more African writings were available. Even areas where there was hardly any in the previous period were covered in books, newspapers, magazines and journals.

In South Africa, African writings were evident in newspapers, letters and legal documents as well as historical narratives. African chiefs such as Dingane, Cetshwayo, Mzilikazi, Lobengula wrote voluminous correspondence on Ancestral laws of their communities. By the end of the 19th century, proto nationalists started expressing their views in newspapers using African languages. Papers like Isidigimi (1870-1880) and Imbo Zabantsundu (The Voice of Black People) which started its publication in 1884 were very useful during that period.

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During the 19th century, more African languages were employed in writing African documents especially in West Africa where Hausa, Kanuri, Fulfulde, Mandara and Kotoko languages were widely used. Some works were by leaders of the Fulani jihad, the political and religious movement founded by Uthman dan Fodio. Mohamed Bello, dan Fodio's son wrote a book Infag al Maysur highlighting the progress of the jihad as well as exploring other histories of the people involved in the jihad. These he relied on oral tradition.

There were African writers who supported or resisted colonialism. Cail Christian Reindorf, a Gold Coast (Ghanaian) African wrote a book, History of Gold Coast and Asante published in 1895 and extolled British colonialism in a poem at the end of the book. Reindorf is thus an example of collaborators. Such a source when being used demonstrates that there were collaborators in the West African setting.

In the same 19th century, however, there were those writers who resisted colonialism. Such writers highlighted Africa's glorious past achievements, civilizations, cultures and empires. In the process, these writers used history to shatter the myth of black people's cultural inferiority. The writers in this group included James Africans B. Horton in his book West African Countries and Peoples: Vindication and Race published in 1869, Edouard W. Blyden, J.W. Sabah, J.E. Casely Hayford and J.B. Danquah.

The 20th century witnessed increased writing by Africans all over the continent as a result of partly the universities, the privileged seats of research were gradually established in Africa. Partly also because of the increased number of Africans who acquired further studies from universities and colleges in former colonial metropolises, United States of America (USA), Unions of Soviet socialist Republic (USSR) and China were equipped to write their views and experiences down. Some of the crucial centres included School of Oriental and African Studies (SOAS) in Britain, Liberia college in Monrovia, Liberia as well as Fourah Bay College in Sierra Leone which had existed since the 19th century.

From 1948, a number of universities came into being in Gold Coast, Nigeria, Sudan, Uganda, Senegal and Congo. Notable nationalist and Panafricanist writers who wrote during the 20th century include S.R.B. Ottah Ahuma who in 1911 published Memoirs of West African Celebrities: 1700-1850, Casely Hayford who in the same year published Ethiopia Bound: Studies in Race Emancipation. Others include Nnamdi Azikiwe's Liberia in World Politics, George Padmore's Pan Africanism or Communism? in 1958, and W.E.B. Dubois' The World and Africa in 1947, Jomo Kenyatta's Facing Mount Kenya in 1938 and Kwameh Nkrumah's Africa Must Unite.

The 1960s and 1970s were, in Tiyaambe Zeleza's Manufacturing African Studies and Crises of 1997 words, decades of boom and expansion in African written sources. Even though there were crises and decline since the 1980s, still todate there are numerous African written sources published in both African and non-African languages. Besides universities, other privileged seats of research and publication emerged. They include Southern African Political and Economic Series (SAPEs), Council for the Development of Social Science Research in Africa (CODESRIA) and Organization for Social Science Research in Eastern and Southern Africa (OSSREA).

Note:

You should note that the 19th and early 20th centuries gave us sources with panafricanist and nationalist views on Africa as well as pro-imperialist ones while late 20th C into this 21st century introduced globalism in these studies.

During the late 20th and into this century global values about human rights, democracy, gender and child sensitivity issues were integrated in the sources. That suggests that African written sources as we read them at present provide information on a wide range of issues affecting the African person both locally and internationally or globally.

5.4 Summary

In this lesson we have seen that African written sources can be traced from the ancient era upto the present and assumed different characters beginning with hieroglyphs and then the Arabic and Greek scripts upto the integrated one that we have at present. The means of writing as well as the topics of concern have been different from time to time. While some African languages like Hausa, Fulfulde, Kiswahili and Amharic were used the fact that at present most learning centres employ European languages also made most current written records be predominantly in European languages. Their themes were not only on cultural and nationalistic themes but also on international and global concerns on human rights, democracy, gender and child sensitivities.

Activity:

Identify any text on history of Africa written by African author(s) and discuss its importance to your perception of African history.

What is the importance of pre 1500 AD African written

Sources?

5.5. Definition of key words

'Hamite'	-	Over time this concept was used to refer to people with some caucasoid influence. Since research has disproved this notion, 'hamites' have been considered mythical. Hence we have 'hamitic myth or hypothesis'.
USSR	-	Union of Soviet Socialist Republic.
USA	-	United States of America
SOAS	-	School of Oriental and African Studies

- SAPES - Southern African Political and Economic Series
- CODESRIA - Council for the Development of Social Science Research in Africa
- OSSREA - Organization for Social Science Research in Eastern and Southern Africa.

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LESSON SIX

6.0 SOCIAL ANTHROPOLOGY

6.1 Introduction

In Lesson 5, we discussed European and African written sources illustrating that both of them have contributions to make in the reconstruction of African history. We learnt that European documents drawing resources from different nations contributed to economic, social and political aspects though with some racist tainting. African written sources on the other hand give us an insiders view of African social, economic and political situations. Though initially scanty, African written sources gradually increased in scope.

In this lesson we will examine social anthropology, its history and usefulness in the reconstruction of African history. We hope to illustrate that as a professional discipline, Social Anthropology brings together both Europeans, and Africans in their study of Africa. Each one of those groups has some contribution to the reconstruction of African history.

6.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:-

- (1) Define what Social Anthropology is.
- (2) Use Social Anthropology as a source in the reconstruction of African history.

6.3 Content

Anthropology as a discipline deals with the science of human beings and their works. Social Anthropology, on the other hand, is a branch of Anthropology and is a useful source of African history.

Both Okot P'Bitek in African Religions in Western Scholarship and Archie Mafeje in Anthropology and Independent Africans: Suicide or End of an Era? argue that social anthropology as an independent study is a product of colonialism and imperialism in the 19th Century. In France and America, the study was founded in 1839 and 1855, respectively. In Britain the study was not taught before 1884 in Oxford, 1900 in Cambridge and 1908 in London. Colonial powers of the time were forced by practical interests in the conditions of life among their subject peoples to carry out studies of those conditions.

France, Germany and Britain started anthropological societies or institutions where they trained personnel who were destined to serve in the colonies. Sir Richard Temple argued in 1904 that social anthropology inculcated into those trained scientific skills for examining the beliefs, customs and institutions of the colonized.

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During the first decade of the 20th Century, a few colonial administrators and settlers began to show anthropological interest in the colonized Africans. But this interest was based on a misconception which was prevalent in the West from the 1850s that non-Western societies such as African ones represented ideal specimens for studying the early stages of human development. African cultures were referred to as 'primitive' or 'savage' cultures and the African peoples were referred to as savages.

Activity:

Look up 'savage' and 'primitive' in your dictionaries and judge European anthropologists' attitudes towards our cultures. Do you agree with their judgements? Give reasons for your answer.

European anthropological misconception about Africans was encouraged by the then prevailing theories of anthropology such as social evolutionary and diffusionist schools, respectively. These theories dominated Europe and America upto the 1920s. Social evolutionist school explained institutions in terms of a line of progress through rigid stages from earlier and simpler forms.

Diffusionists explained institutions in terms of the external contacts and connections and argued that cultures were a development of traits borrowed from others. These traits could be classified and their movements could be reconstructed even across continents and oceans.

Another theory which influenced anthropologists from the 1920s was functionalism. This theory was pioneered by Malinowski and Radcliffe Brown. Functionalists contended that the present can be understood in terms of its own contemporary structures, each part functioning to maintain the integrity of the whole. Their main emphasis was on equilibrium rather than change implying that communities being studied had no history.

Functionalists posited that in order to study contemporary colonial world, one needed to participate in the life of the people studied. One needed to observe rather than to ask question because function was often unconscious and one required to analyze in a synchronic way as if the data had been gathered at a single moment in time.

Note:

You should note that these aspects about Social Anthropology imply the need for caution in applying the theories because they did not put historical process into serious consideration when collecting data,

Social Anthropology is based on the assumption that collected data is not affected by the social, economic, political and chronological factors. Social anthropologists assumed that African communities were static and unprogressive.

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Herein lies the question of relevance in anthropological theory. First, what is a theory? Mafeje in the cited work in the lesson, posits that theory has no fixed meaning hence different disciplines have their own idea of theory. However, it is the business of theory to explain hidden connections in its field of relevance. There can be more than one theory in any discipline as the case of Social Anthropology has indicated in social evolution, diffusion, functionalism structuralism, and descent and alliance theories.

Given that social anthropological material is not conscious of historical environment, it follows that its materials including its theories when employed by history practitioners have to be adroitly analyzed to serve historical purposes. This is not unique with anthropology. Indeed, at the moment, history similarly borrows theories from sociology, economics as well as other social sciences. Once deemed fit for historical purposes, they are adapted to historical process.

Most anthropological works on African communities suffer from lack of an analysis of historical conditions which affected the respective communities at the time of research. Taking examples from Kenya, works on Agikuyu, Okiek, Akamba, Kalenjin, Abaluyia, Ameru, Mijikenda, Luo and Maasai vindicate the assertion. Maybe it is in Kenyatta's Facing Mount Kenya where background information is provided about the circumstances surrounding his time of writing. One expects this consciousness to be manifested in the works of Nnamdi Azikiwe and K.A. Busia who like Kenyatta are Africans and undertook the study of Anthropology about the same time in the 1930s.

Activity:

Trace the development of social anthropology from its inception to the 1950s.

The Role of Social Anthropology in Reconstructing African History

Despite the shortcomings associated with Social Anthropology, it is a useful source to historians in our reconstruction of the past. African historians including B.A. Ogot, G.S. Were, M.S. Kiwanuka, I.N. Kimambo and G. Muriuki have greatly benefited from the material provided by Social Anthropology.

Anthropological materials which described and explained beliefs and customs of various African communities are vital raw data which historians employ to study both precolonial and colonial periods of specific communities. Social Anthropology material has been resourceful in enabling practitioners in portraying various reasons behind the behaviour and events of the African people's past including their social, political and military conduct.

Furthermore, anthropological theories such as discussed earlier have provided useful paradigms to history students in their study of various communities, institutions and ideas. Indeed, history practitioners working among precolonial African communities strongly employ Social Anthropology to determine time concepts among such specific

peoples. Thus that some communities' time concepts are linear or cyclic is due to anthropological findings.

For instance, Alan Jacobs concluded that the Maasai chronology depended on age-sets because of his skillful anthropological research. Going by Jacob's findings as contained in Hadith I, historians researching into the pastoral past of the Maa speaking communities successfully allotted specific periods.

However, because social anthropologists based their research on the present, historians apply anthropological findings as a way of understanding conditions which prevailed at the anthropologists' time of studying. Such conditions enable history practitioners to visualize how people's behaviour and events were, in more distance past. In doing this, historians skillfully gear the anthropological data to serve in the reconstruction of history. A case in point is in the explosion of the 'hamitic' myth which had a lot of anthropological and racist fallacies about the African communities. Historical studies in Africa have proved that 'hamitic' myth mainly served the European racist interests.

The current discipline of Social Anthropology studied in our universities is under pressure to depart from the colonialists' perspective. Notable social anthropologists like Mafeje and Kwesi Prah have had to seek dialogue with other social science disciplines such as economics and history to reorient the study in line with Afrocentricity and Africanity. Afrocentricity as Mafeje defines in CODESRIA Bulletin Vol. I, 2000 refers to a methodological requirement for decolonizing knowledge in Africa whereas Africanity is an assertion of an identity that has been denied. It is a panafricanist revulsion against external imposition by others.

Materials produced since 1970s have tended to embrace Africanity as away of repackaging this discipline so as to render it more relevant to Africa. Such material is of greater use to historians interested in various aspects of respective African communities. However, Social Anthropology is only one of the many sources which are employed in the reconstruction of African history. On its own, Social Anthropology is inadequate. It requires reinforcement from others like oral tradition, other written sources, archaeology and linguistics.

6.4 Summary

In this lesson we have seen that Social Anthropology emerged as a tool to serve colonialists in their mission in Africa. However, with time the discipline has also carried useful data and theoretical paradigms which are useful to historians in the writing of African history. Hence, we have cautioned that, since it did not pay much attention to factors of time change, history practitioners have to readapt such materials in such a way that can render their use worthwhile.

Activity:

What is the role of theory in history?
Use a Social Anthropological theory to
illustrate

6.5 Definition of Key Words

Africanity – is an assertion of an identity that has been denied. It is a panafricanist revulsion against external imposition by others.

Afrocentricity – Is a methodological requirement to decolonize knowledge in Africa.

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LESSON SEVEN

7.0 ORAL TRADITION AND ORAL HISTORY

7.1 Introduction

In the previous lesson we discussed the importance of Social Anthropology as a source of African History. We hopefully illustrated that as a source, social Anthropology has considerably assisted history practitioners in reconstructing African History.

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The present lesson examines oral tradition and oral history. It is this use of 'oral word' that European racists ignored in their examination of those sources which can contribute to African history. Here we hope to argue that without the oral word, the written word would perhaps not have come into existence. Consequently, we hope to show that oral tradition and oral history are important tools in the writing of African history.

7.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson you should be able to:

- (1) Define oral tradition and oral history.
- (2) Demonstrate the importance of oral tradition and oral history in the reconstruction of African History.

7.3 Content

Oral tradition and oral history are important sources of African history. Without Oral tradition a lot of our African past in particular, or the entire world in general, would have been lost. For instance, Joseph Ki-Zerbo argues that nearly all the history of the world has been spoken before it has been written. He cites the Bible and the Koran as having first come into existence because of oral tradition before eventually being published in print form. In addition, Bethwell Alan Ogot demonstrates that European countries bring up their children on the oral tradition of Ancient Greece and Rome. Therefore oral tradition forms a fundamental base for human history.

a) What is oral tradition?

The concept of oral tradition has been variously defined by historians. For instance, Jan Vansina defines it as a testimony transmitted verbally from one generation to another. Here the key terms are 'testimony' and 'transmitted verbally'. In elaborating further on the term 'testimony', Vansina states that it refers to all statements made by one person about a single sequence of past events provided that the person had not acquired new information between the various statements. Should new acquisitions occur, the testimonies will be contaminated resulting in a new tradition. For instance, Rwandese informants related two versions of a tradition about the Tutsi and the Hutu communities.

In one account issues in May 1958 by the most conservative wing of the Tutsi, it justified Tutsi rule by recalling a story of origin according to which the Tutsi had fallen from heaven and since had lorded it over the Hutu. The second account was by Hutu intellectuals who claimed that the Hutu, Tutsi and Twa social categories were brothers. This variation vividly shows that oral tradition can be applied to enhance certain interests and implies a need for one to make certain that all segments of the population are heard.

Joseph Ki-Zerbo, on the other hand defines oral tradition as the collection of all the types of witness transmitted verbally by people through their own past. The key words are 'witness' and 'transmitted verbally'. These key words closely agree with Vansina's

definition. Hence the two scholars' perceptions and articulation of oral tradition is basically the same.

Our final example is given by Henry S.K. Mwaniki who defines oral tradition as the process of handing down information, opinions, beliefs and customs by word of mouth or by example. The key words in this definition are 'handing down', 'word of mouth' or 'by example'. Mwaniki elaborates further by arguing that it is a transmission of knowledge and institutions through successive generations without written instructions. Barring minor details, this perception similarly and broadly fits in the category of the other two above.

Note:

It is important to note then that oral tradition transmits knowledge and institutions through successive generations verbally and by example.

Oral history, unlike oral tradition does not require transmitting from several earlier generations to the present. Rather, it is oral reminiscences, the first hand recollections by people who were themselves witness of what they recount to the young generation or researchers. In both oral tradition and oral history, the role of the eyewitness is crucial. The eyewitness is an immediate source and not a transmitted one. Here the risk of distorting the testimony is minimal. Consequently, any valid oral tradition should be based on an eye witness account.

Rumour is not necessarily based on an eye-witness account. It transmits a message which depends on hearsay. However, when frequently repeated, rumour develops into a tradition.

Activity:

In your own words distinguish between oral tradition and oral history.

(b) The Nature of Oral Tradition

Oral tradition is divided into two general categories:

- (i) The first category is consciously historical in purpose and context. Included here are myths, legends, genealogies, proverbs and other stories about the peoples' past beliefs, experiences and institutions. For instance, the Misri myth, the Gikuyu myth of creation and the Legend of Lwanda Magere. Such accounts are usually utilitarian in purpose like when the speaker aims at confirming hereditary dignities and possessions, the right to own and use certain pieces of land, or to console people during calamities such as death.
- (ii) Imaginative literature or orature includes songs in praise of living or dead heroes or heroines (epic poems), incantations used in communions with gods and ancestors and stories employed in divination rites. The historical value and content of these songs, chants and stories is often not very

obvious. But a careful study of them yields some useful pieces of information for work in the reconstruction process of the past.

Steven Feierman's work, The Shambaa Kingdom: A History is a product of an historical analysis. Feierman records the myth of Mbegha, a hero tradition which tells of a hunter who came to Shambaa from the South. The myth tells how Mbegha killed wild pigs in Shambaa and settled difficult disputes. All the Shambaa welcomed him and spontaneously made him king. The myth is a rich statement in which the Shambaa describe the values of their society and the fundamental lasting characteristics of Shambaa political life.

All the above forms of oral tradition, narratives, genealogies, songs, incantations and proverbs are mainly preserved by elders and specialists who have learnt them by heart. Such elders and specialists are found in every African community. In West Africa we have the griots, among the Baganda were the court poets, among the Kuba are the Bulaam while in some sections of the Abaluyia are traditional custodians and public counselors (Abaseni ba Omuse).

Information held by the specialists is invaluable in the reconstruction of our history – yet a lot of it is being irretrievably lost whenever any oral tradition specialist dies. In order to salvage some of the information, students of history and other social sciences should assign themselves the fundamental task of recording down or on tapes whatever information specialists and elders can offer for our use and that of posterity.

c) Chronology in Oral Tradition

Chronology is important in any historical reconstruction. Chronology makes it possible to distinguish the periodical sequence of events. This, however, is best obtained when using absolute chronology. Oral tradition does not give such absolute chronology but a relative one. Thus dating in oral tradition is based on general periods rather than exact numerical dates.

Note:

You should note that in 'centralized' states king-lists and 'commoner' genealogies are useful means of providing relative chronology. Among 'stateless' societies genealogies, generation or age-sets are employed in determining relative chronology.

Where possible relative chronology is reinforced by available recorded dates. This is usually done by relating oral evidence to natural phenomena such as earthquakes and eclipses whose dates are known. Also through archaeological and socio-linguistic methods, more precise dates can be provided to strengthen chronology in oral tradition.

d) Limitations of Oral Tradition

Given that oral tradition is handed down from one generation to another by word of mouth, any slight lapse of memory adversely affects the delivery of information. For instance, 16th century issues may very easily be lost if informants' memories fail them, especially when we know that there is no living witness to such events. This eventuality befell issues related to the Sirikwa and Misri stories. So far the exact circumstances surrounding the Sirikwa community and the Misri origin are not clear because no living informant has clearly explained away the mystery. What we currently have are conflicting theories.

The existence of written documents often corrupts oral tradition. Most present oral tradition specialists are literate or semi-literate and are often likely to accept the already written versions believing that the written word is more valid. This view needs to be corrected to make informants aware that if there are other versions which are not already recorded, informants should narrate them to researchers.

Language barrier often adversely affects researchers working in communities who speak different languages or dialects. This difficulty results in researchers hiring interpreters. Yet once information is translated from one language to another, it loses some vital information which would have been of help to the researcher. The problem is based on the fact that no two languages can be exact in meaning. Hence, whether a researcher hired an expert to translate and interpret or not, certain values must just be lost in the process of translation and interpretation.

Secrecy connected with certain ritual practices limits the usefulness of oral traditions. For instance, elders who underwent certain secret initiation rituals committed themselves to keep those practices secret. Besides, such elders would have been afraid of inquiring about specific concepts in the rituals. Consequently, a lot of information has been lost. Here, perhaps we as history students need to go about it cautiously enough to gather little that is left for our use and that of future generations.

Note:

It is worthwhile to note that whatever the limitations, oral sources still remain crucial especially in our reconstruction of our precolonial past. Memory is believed to retain information of upto five hundred years ago. Nonetheless, it is advisable to use oral sources in conjunction with other sources, where possible, in order to off-set the shortcomings associated with oral tradition.

7.4 Summary

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This lesson has examined the topic of oral tradition and oral history by first defining them and proceeding to demonstrate the nature and scope of oral sources. We have argued that oral sources are important in our reconstruction of particularly the precolonial period.

Activity:

Illustrate how historians have relied on oral sources to reconstruct especially the precolonial and colonial African history.

7.5 Definition of Key Words

‘Abaseni ba Omuse’ is a Luyia word used to refer to oral tradition specialists who are invited to give cultural history of some Abaluyia subethnic groups on funeral occasions of respected elders.

7.6 Further Reading

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LESSON EIGHT

8.0 MODES OF CARRYING OUT RESEARCH

8.1 Introduction

The previous lesson focused on the topic of 'Oral Tradition and Oral History and hoped to highlight the meaning, nature and usefulness of the two in the reconstruction of African history.

In this lesson we now turn our attention to the modes of carrying our research in History. It is hoped that through this discussion we will shed light on what a student should equip himself/herself with before writing a term paper, research paper or book review.

8.2 Objectives

By the end of this lesson you should be able to:

- (1) Identify various modes of carrying out library and oral research.
- (2) Use library and oral data in the writing of African history.

8.3 Content

'Modes of carrying our research' signifies ways of handling a problem, something which needs describing, explaining, or improving on, or about which more information is needed in order to make prediction and policy formulation possible. This definition by Margaret Peil in her Social Science Research Methods is further reinforced by Robert Ross who in Research: An Introduction defines a problem as a perplexing question which demands that one solves it, and to solve it one sets out to state it very clearly.

For our purpose, being interested in researching about history, our puzzling question becomes a historical problem. The two ways in which to identify a historical problem are (i) source oriented and (ii) problem oriented. Source oriented is though suited for a leisurely research, it can turn out to be useful in facilitating a problem oriented counterpart.

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Joh Tosh in his The Pursuit of History argues that in a source oriented research a historian takes one source or group of sources which fall within his or her general area of interest and extracts whatever is of value allowing the content of the source to determine the nature of the inquiry. For the problem oriented approach, a historian has to formulate a specific historical question which is prompted by a reading of the secondary authorities. This is followed by studying relevant primary sources. The bearing which these sources may have on other issues is ignored. The researcher proceeds as directly as possible to the point where he or she can present some conclusions.

In practice, neither of these approaches is usually pursued to the complete exclusion of the other. But the balance struck between them varies a great deal. Some historians begin their careers with a narrowly defined project while others are let loose on a major archive or oral field interviews with only the vaguest of briefs.

Our current concern, however, is not so much to discuss full blown researches that require bigger projects as opposed to minor and localised researches on specific assignments by our teachers. Included in these localised projects are term papers, research papers and book reviews. Research in these areas may not begin by searching out for new sources as contrasted to turning to well known materials with new questions in the mind.

In this process the relationship between the historian and his/her source should be one of give and take.

Note:

You should take note that sources only speak when they are spoken to, and they will not talk to strangers. Similarly they may not be forthcoming to anyone in a tearing hurry. Therefore, even for experienced researchers, research is time consuming and can be painfully slow.

a) Collecting, Storing and Analysis of Evidence

In the process of collection which involves looking into the community of knowledge available to you, the topic you are working on needs to be kept in mind if you have to locate and select materials. Whether one is engaged in big research project or a minor one, library materials are the preliminary sources that researchers consult before proceeding to venture into the field.

Thus in preparation for the library search you must have a pen, or a pencil, a notebook or papers ready for use. Once the stationery is available, the next step is to locate the reading materials. If they are in a well documented library, the researcher follows the classification system to identify where the subject is. For our interest, history is in the

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section labelled 'D' in both Moi Library and Jomo Kenyatta Memorial Library of Kenyatta University and University of Nairobi, respectively.

Activity:

Now go to your nearest library and identify which section is for history. Where is the section for African history?

In the two libraries mentioned above, 'African history' is found in the section classified as 'DT'. Hence, it will be at the section where the researcher's specific interest lies which will be the place for him/her to start the search.

Or better still, the researcher goes to the area where the card catalogue is and browses through the subject catalogue identifying texts which may be relevant to his/her subject area. Every time he/she notes it down starting with the author, title and call number as below:-

Kenyatta J.

Suffering Without Bitterness

DT
435.6
K4
A3

Nairobi, East African
Publishing House, 1968

Once the researcher has identified the materials and their call numbers, he/she will head for where in the library to get them. In our Moi library, books are located in open shelves and in special reserve sections for short lending. The special sections are classified as 'short loan' and 'Africana' section.

Given the interdisciplinary nature of our history research, the search cannot be confined to the section of history alone. It is imperative that the researcher looks at subject catalogues of other social sciences to identify works which may be useful in enriching the research. The researcher then writes down the identified work as before.

Davidson Alastair,

HT
288
97
D32

Antonio Gramsci: Towards an Intellectual Biography
London, Merlin Press, 1977

Apart from subject specific titles which are identified and located through card catalogues, other supplementary materials which serve general purposes exist in the library for reference. These later materials are not on card catalogues. Reference , materials fall into two classifications:

- (a) General reference works such as encyclopaedia that provide bibliographical or factual information on a variety of subjects.
- (b) Specific reference works such as periodicals on social sciences that give bibliographical or factual information on a single subject or group of subjects.

Libraries also contain newspapers and magazines which cover a variety of topics. It is advisable to take note of their availability so that at the time of perusal the researcher consults them as well. This means that they can be read just like other reference materials.

The same tools are useful in collecting materials in the Kenya National Archives. Pens, notebooks, pencils and rubbers are useful tools. Materials in the archives are also catalogued, recorded in special documents or stored in the computer.

A researcher consults the archivist for assistance in getting the correct documents which can guide him/her in looking for information. The Kenya National Archives contains useful books, colonial records, microfilms and audio-visual films. Other than any other sources, archival materials form very useful primary sources for history.

Activity:

Now looking at the research assignments you have in this text, go to the library or archive and make a list of relevant materials for your work.

Oral sources also make use of pens, notebooks, pencils and rubbers just as is with library and archival documents. But in addition a tape recorder, a questionnaire or question guide and a camera may be needed. To locate an informant a purposive and snowballing sampling approaches are preferred. This is because not every person is knowledgeable in the field one is interested in. Consequently, by applying a purposive and snowballing sampling approaches, a researcher is shown informants who may be resourceful in his/her area of interest.

Note:

In selecting materials, you do not need to read through entire books, pamphlets or periodicals to determine their relevance to the topic of research. A preface, forward, introduction, table of contents, textual aids, the epilogue or appendix or appendices and index or indices are adequate in showing a researcher whether the book is relevant to his/her search or not.

Credibility of the writer or informant is crucial. It is important to inquire about his/her reliability by going through his/her works as well as works written by others about him/her. On the side of oral informants, it pays to learn from the neighbours about their views of the informant before her/his reliability could be taken seriously. This is a point

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which was underscored by H.E. Carr when he wrote that before one reads a book, first he/she should read about the author. This process is what Tosh refers to as external criticism.

Note:

You should familiarise with the ten points of importance in research

- (1) Know the subject under investigation
- (2) Use tools provided in the materials.
- (3) Sample the materials.
- (4) Check the publication dates
- (5) Investigate the author(s) and publisher(s)' qualifications.
- (6) Compare sources on the same subject
- (7) Determine the extent and method of research that went into the work
- (8) Use reference guides
- (9) Rely on instructors and librarians' experience for guidance.
- (10) Rely on the communities' and peer groups' experience for guidance about the oral informants.

Recording Evidence

Once the material is located, selected and evaluated, record bibliographical information of the sources and make notes on the evidence. When the sources are books, form a working bibliography by recording each entry accurately and completely on 3x5 inch index cards. The importance of making a complete bibliographical card immediately after selecting a source is because cards serve to relocate sources, document references and compile a final bibliography.

Note Taking

Notes record facts from the sources. These facts support and develop ideas in your paper, dissertation, book review or thesis. At that point, facts evolve into developmental materials, including details, examples, direct quotations, statistics, definitions and analogies.

Notes are often written in note books or note-cards. If a note card is used:

- (1) The cardinal rule is that each card should have only one note or idea
- (2) Notes should be written legibly
- (3) Bibliographical source need not be written on the note card. The details are found on the bibliographical card.
- (4) Record the number or numbers of the page or pages from which the page was taken. If the note was taken from two or more pages, place a slash mark within the note to indicate at what point the page number changes.
- (5) Indicate the subject of the note at the top of the card in order to facilitate sorting and organizing the cards at a later time.

Activity:

Basing on the assignment you have in this module, prepare your bibliographical and note-taking cards. Discuss how you go about performing these tasks up to the analysis state.

Presentation of Research Results

Having collected, stored and analyzed the data, the remaining process involves organizing and writing of the research project. For your case, it could be a term paper, a book review or a field project report. In the first place, the evidence should once again be surveyed to test the validity.

Next, decide how to approach the subject and guided by the organizational pattern which the approach suggests, list all parts of the research problem in the conventional form of the outline. Determine the approach and make the outline lead directly into writing the rough draft.

Interpretation

In order to interpret facts or ideas meaningfully, one should understand them thoroughly and approach them objectively. Historians rely on interpretations of evidence to arrive at conclusions. The next step is making an outline based on the investigation. An outline serves as a reliable guide for writing the rough draft. A problem topic or the assignment statement should be at the beginning of the outline.

Note:

You note the five stages a researcher follows in writing a research project;

- (1) Organize the evidence on note cards or in note books according to the outline.
- (2) Understand the kinds of evidence and their derivatives: the Developmental materials.
- (3) Use the evidence effectively by writing a rough draft
- (4) Give credit to the sources of evidence through documentation.
- (5) Turn the rough draft into a finished paper

Parts of the Rough Draft

- Introduction
- The body
- Conclusion

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The introduction sets forth what is to be discussed and could even state what will not be included. It also summarizes an opposing idea and dispense of it before introducing a particular idea which forms the study.

The body is the major part of a research project. It progresses logically from one idea to another substantiating the generalizations on the outline with specific developmental materials such as details, examples and quotations.

Conclusion recapitulates the ideas of the research project and links it with the first paragraph neatly. A conclusion can also extend a challenge to the reader calling on him/her to help effect solutions.

When the whole rough draft is finished, revision is very important. During revision, the researcher pays particular attention to (a) development of ideas (b) exactness of expression. Once all this is done, a final draft is written.

Referencing

This is a technique which scholars employ in demonstrating honesty and professionalism in their search for truth. Various forms of referencing exist. We have in-text citation, footnoting, end-noting and bibliographing. Our interest here is in footnoting and bibliographing which we wish to encourage you to apply.

Footnoting is when a work which is quoted in the body is numbered and details of the quote written at the top or bottom of the page.

Points to note in footnotes

- (a) Each quote is numbered and subsequently the number, the author, title, place, publishers, year and page(s) written at the foot of the page eg.

Martin Bernal. The Black Athena Vol.1. London, Free Association Books, 1987:86.

- (b) Author(s) names can either start in initials or first names.
- (c) Book titles are underlined or put in bold letters while articles are inverted commas or italicized.
- (d) A work in edited text starts with author, title of article, in name of editor's name, titled of edited work, place of publication, publisher, year and page(s) e.g.
A. Hampate Ba 'The Living tradition' in J.Ki-Zerbo ed. General History of Africa: Methodology and African Prehistory. California, USA Heinemann, 1981.
- (e) 'Ibid' is used to refer to a source similar to the one immediately above, while op. cit refers to a source similar to a work cited at least in the third position above or much earlier.
- (f) In writing ibid one need not indicate the author(s)' names since it is included in the one immediately above. But in op.cit writing the author(s)' names helps to guide the reader or examiner of your work.
- (g) To be more familiar with this approach read more of the further reading list.

Bibliographies

- (a) In writing a bibliography, author(s)' names start with surnames, and written in full instead of initials.
- (b) Authors' names are arranged in an ascending alphabetical order.
- (c) Titles of articles are punctuated while those of published texts are underlined.
- (d) An article in an edited work follows the format of first name of author, article title put in inverted commas, in the names of the editor(s), the title of the edited work in which it appears, the place of publication, publisher(s) and year.
- (e) The word 'anonymous' is used in works whose author(s) is/are individually or collectively not indicated.
- (f) Newspapers and magazines are often written in the way their titles appear without indicating authors or publishers.

8.4 Summary

We have learnt about modes of carrying out research and found out that before any person embarks on a research he/she needs to have a problem clearly articulated. In the research process several stages have been examined including collecting, storing, analyzing and presenting the findings. We have also seen that in documenting your work, you need to footnote and at the end present a bibliography. It is hoped that you will be making use of this guide to write a good term paper, book review and research paper.

8.5 Definition of Key Words

Purposive and snowball sampling –

Is a research sampling method in which a researcher starts his/her interview with specific informants he/she was given in advance. But once started, those informants direct him/her to others. Hence from the initial few, more are added.

Research problem – This is a perplexing question which demands that a researcher solves it. It is supposed to be clearly and unambiguously stated.

8.6 Further Reading

Carr, E.H. What is History? Hammondsworth, Penguin, 1964.

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